

Table of Contents

AGENDA	4
BOARD OF MANAGEMENT as at 30 June 2010	5
STAFF SUMMARY as at 30 June 2010	6
MINUTES OF 2009 ANNUAL GENERAL MEETING	8
ATTENDANCE & APOLOGIES (2009 AGM)	12
FUNDING PARTNERSHIPS 2009-2010	14
CLIENTS BY ETHNIC BACKGROUND	14
OFFICE LOCATIONS & SERVICE REGIONS	15
CHAIRMAN'S REPORT	16
CHIEF EXECUTIVE OFFICER'S REPORT	18
SPECIAL PROJECTS TEAM – Introduction	21
IMMIGRATION ADVICE & ASSISTANCE (IAAAS)	22
COMPLEX CASE SUPPORT (CCS)	24
RURAL TEAM – Introduction	26
RURAL SUPPORT SETTLEMENT GRANTS PROGRAM	27
HUNTER WELFARE OUTREACH SETTLEMENT GRANTS PROGRAM	29
NEW ENGLAND SETTLEMENT GRANTS PROGRAM (ARMIDALE)	31
NEW ENGLAND SETTLEMENT GRANTS PROGRAM (TAMWORTH)	33
NEW ENGLAND SETTLEMENT GRANTS PROGRAM (INVERELL)	35
CENTRAL COAST TEAM - Introduction	37
MULTICULTURAL SOCIAL SUPPORT SERVICE	38
MULTICULTURAL SOCIAL SUPPORT SERVICE	40
SETTLEMENT GRANTS PROGRAM – CENTRAL COAST	42
MULTICULTURAL FAMILY SUPPORT PROJECT – CENTRAL COAST	44
AGED SERVICES TEAM - Introduction	46
COMMUNITY AGED CARE PACKAGES	47
HUNTER MULTICULTURAL RESPITE SERVICE	50

Table of Contents-continued

COMMUNITY VISITORS SCHEME	53
MULTICULTURAL ACCESS PROJECT – HUNTER	56
REFUGEE SUPPORT TEAM – Introduction	58
REFUGEE SUPPORT TEAM LEADER	59
REFUGEE WELFARE, AFRICAN COMMUNITIES PROJECT	62
AFRICAN YOUTH PROJECT	64
PARENTING SUPPORT PROJECT	66
LIFE SKILLS & PARENTING GROUPS	68
AFRICAN FAMILY WELFARE PROJECT	70
AFRICAN PARENTING ASSISTANT	71
AFRICAN FAMILY SUPPORT PROJECT (Mauritanian)	72
VOLUNTEER CO-ORDINATION	73
WELFARE TEAM – Introduction	76
FILIPINO WELFARE PROJECT	77
BRIGHTER FUTURES PROGRAM	80
RUSSIAN WELFARE PROJECT	82
THAI WELFARE PROJECT	84
PACIFIC ISLANDER WELFARE PROJECT	86
MULTICULTURAL FAMILY SUPPORT PROJECT (FAMILIES FIRST)	88
FINANCE & ADMINISTRATION TEAM –Newcastle & Central Coast	91
CENTRE USAGE – 2009-2010	92
PHOTOS	93
FINANCIAL REPORTS 2009-2010	97
-Cutcher & Neale Chartered Accountants (pgs.1-28)	

NOTICE IS HEREBY GIVEN OF THE
26th ANNUAL GENERAL MEETING
OF
NORTHERN SETTLEMENT SERVICES LIMITED

TO BE HELD ON THURSDAY 25 NOVEMBER 2010
AT 8 CHAUCER STREET HAMILTON
AT 11.00am

AGENDA

1. OPENING & WELCOME
BY CHAIRMAN, MR HENRY CHAN OAM
2. APOLOGIES
3. MINUTES OF 2009 AGM
4. BUSINESS ARISING
5. PRESENTATION OF REPORTS
6. CONFIRMATION OF AUDITORS
7. ELECTION -NSS BOARD OF MANAGEMENT (2011)
8. GENERAL BUSINESS
9. CLOSE & LIGHT REFRESHMENTS

Board of Management - 30 June 2010

Mr Henry Chan OAM	Chairman
Mr William Simanowsky	Deputy Chairman
Ms Trudy Mills-Evers AM	Treasurer, Public Officer, Finance & Audit Committee
Ms Biko Syongoh	Assistant Treasurer, Finance & Audit Committee
Ms Sania Young	Assistant Secretary, Finance & Audit Committee
Ms Christine Jordan	Assistant Secretary
Fr Nicholas Zervas OAM	Director, Australia Day Committee, OAM
Ms Zoran Vasiljevic	Director
Ms Anna Marendy	Director
Ms Carla Silva	Director
Mr James Garvey	Director
Resignations:	Ms Irina Lupish (<i>nominated as Secretary, AGM 2009</i>)

Staff Summary – 30 June 2010

Chief Executive Officer / Special Project Team Leader	Violetta Walsh OAM
Deputy Chief Executive Officer / Migration Agent	Lulu Tantos
Migration Agent	Irina Lupish*/Richard Hardy
Financial Controller	Arlene Richards
Assistant Financial Controller	Marianne Mohr
Office Manager	Mary Milevski
Information & Referral: Reception Staff	Silvia Ruano-McLerie*/Helen Short
	Lydia Manusiu, Wendy Kirkham, Jacinta Boidin
OH&S Consultant	Helen Buchanan
Rural Projects Team Leader	Alex Burns
Hunter Welfare Outreach SGP	Rose Oku
New England SGP Worker (Tamworth)	Amalin Sundaravej
New England SGP Worker (Armidale)	Judith Roberts
New England SGP Worker (Inverell)	Mary Prendergast*/Katie Wright
Central Coast Team Leader	Alex Burns
Central Coast Office Manager	Trudy Wahl*/Sharlene Huber
Multicultural Social Support Service Coordinator	Olivia Fuente
Multicultural Social Support Service Trainee Coordinator	Julie Styles
Multicultural Social Support Service Coordinator	Anita Trainor
Central Coast SGP Worker	Danielle Habib
Multicultural Family Worker	Pari Batha
Aged Services Team Leader / Community Aged Care Packages Coordinator	Sue Hristov
Community Aged Care Packages Coordinator	Lupe Fonua
Community Aged Care Packages Coordinator / Tax Help Officer	Tima 'Oto
Hunter Multicultural Respite Service Coordinator	Tima 'Oto
Community Visitors Scheme Coordinator	Enza Di Stefano
Multicultural Access Project Worker (<i>commenced 10/09</i>)	Valerie Woodman

Staff Summary – continued

Refugee Support Team Leader / Complex Case Support Coordinator	Kiri Hata
African Communities Worker	Flora Aine*
African Youth Worker	Tonkoh Kamara
Parenting Support Project Worker	Zenaida Edmunds
Life Skills & Parenting Groups Project Officer	Helen Buchanan
African Family Support Project Worker	Joselyne Ntahomvukiye
African Parenting Assistant	Amer Manyun
Mauritanian Welfare Workers	Robyn Graham*/Alhousseynou Ly*
Volunteers Coordinator (Educational Programs)	Michael Freund
Volunteers Coordinator (Welfare Programs)	Olivia Graham*/ Georgina Ramsay
Welfare Projects Team Leader / Filipino Welfare Worker	Petrona Kelly
Brighter Futures Project Officer	
Multicultural Family Worker (Families First)	Miza Torlakovic
Pacific Islander Welfare Worker (Samoan) / Tax Help Officer / EAPA	Juanita Loli
Pacific Islander Welfare Worker (Tongan)	Lydia Manusiu*/ Finau Manu
Russian Welfare Worker	Elena Ferguson
Thai Welfare Worker	Nellie Srisurapon

**Indicates has left position at time of print*

MINUTES OF 2009 ANNUAL GENERAL MEETING

THURSDAY 26 NOVEMBER 2009, 11.00AM.

MEMBERS OF NORTHERN SETTLEMENT SERVICES LIMITED

Minutes: Mary Milevski (Office Manager)

1. **ATTENDANCE:** as per lists

2. **APOLOGIES:** as per lists

3. **MINUTES for AGM 2009 – Accepted**

Proposed: Fthr N Zervas

Seconded: SYoung

4. **BUSINESS ARISING:**

- VWalsh said that negotiations to re-auspice DOCS & DIAC projects at NSS Central Coast were in progress.
- The NSS Audit Committee continued to meet every 3 months – minutes & recommendations are tabled to Board regularly.
- Acknowledgement of the death of Mr Klopčič (Board Director) on 28/11/08
- The third Homework Centre has been established & is operational at Waratah.

5. **PRESENTATION OF STAFF REPORTS:**

H Chan - Chairman, NSS Board: Report tabled & accepted as read.

- Gave recognition & thanked VWalsh for her efforts towards the successful attainment of the PBI status

VWalsh - CEO: Report tabled & accepted as read.

- Welcomed Val Woodman – Multicultural Access Worker, Aged Services Team
- Acknowledged the end of the citizenship support program.
- Continuing excellent relationship with Penola House & thanked it's chief, Sr Betty Brown who was in attendance.

LTantos - Deputy CEO, Migration Agent: Report tabled & accepted as read

- Apologies from Richard Hardy, unable to attend AGM (works for NSS on a contractual arrangement)
- Thanked & acknowledged Irina Lupish for her service as a Migration Agent for NSS
- LTantos said the migration service continued & complies with the contractual obligations (DIAC)

KHata - Complex Case Support: Report tabled & accepted as read

- Progressing well.

Rural Team: Reports tabled & accepted as read

- ABurns said that Inverell worker Katie Wright will resign from position.

Aged Services: Reports tabled & accepted as read

- SHristov welcomed Val Woodman to the team.
- SHristov thanked the members of her team for their support while she was on leave
- Enza DiStefano (CVS) acknowledged the work of the volunteers in the CVS project
- Val Woodman stated that she has operated 5 weeks in the Multicultural Access position. She thanked VWalsh & staff for the welcoming environment. She said she looks forward to making a difference with her project work. She also acknowledged level of professionalism & expertise at NSS, & the cultural diversity.

Central Coast Team: Reports tabled & accepted as read

- Pari Batha said the terms of her move to NSS were very difficult, however she thanked NSS Management for their sensitivity & welcome. She said it was great to be working with NSS.

African Team: Reports tabled & accepted as read

- Team Leader KHata said the team has been extended to include Zeni Edmunds & Nellie Srisurapon (total of 11 members)
- KHata said there has been a shift in the 'make-up' of refugees in the area.
- KHata also suggested there could be a potential change of name for the team to better describe the work of the team.
- TKamara said that the Youth project has been broadened to include new groups & communities.
- HBuchanan, MFreund & OGraham offered their thanks to office staff for their support. HBuchanan issued her thanks to staff for 'keeping safe', from her position of OH&S consultant for the organisation.
- MFreund said that it had been a strong year for volunteer recruitment & activity. He also mentioned that the addition of another Homework Centre meant that 4 were currently operating with 50 participants & 40 volunteers. He also welcomed Olivia Graham as his Assistant (Welfare & Volunteer Orientation)

Welfare Team: Reports tabled & accepted as read

- Team Leader Petrona Kelly welcomed Finau Manu as the new Tongan Welfare Worker
- It was mentioned that Nellie Srisurapon maintains the Thai Welfare project in the Welfare Team as well as being involved in the African team
- MTorlakovic has tendered her apologies as she is on leave
- NSrisurapon thanks her colleagues for their support, particularly ABurns & LTantos & also thanked the Administration staff.
- LTantos acknowledged Juanita's management of the community contributions regarding the recent Samoan tragedy.
- ZEdmunds said that she had mixed feelings about the end of her two year project supporting refugee & migrant women, however was looking forward to continuing to support the group through her role in the African team.
- HChan & VWalsh thanked the Finance & Administration Teams for their dedication & professional standard of work throughout another year.

STAFF REPORTS – Accepted

Proposed: CJordan
Seconded: Fthr N Zervas

6. FINANCIAL REPORTS:

- Cutcher & Neale representative Glen Peterkin presented the reports & provided a brief overview.
- GPetekin said that the PBI status was of major benefit to the organisation. He congratulated VWalsh & the NSS Finance team on another year of excellent financial management of the organisation.
- He offered apologies on behalf of Mark O'Connor, who was unable to attend the AGM due to other engagements.
- TMills-Evers offered her special mention to the NSS Accounts Team & thanked ARichards & MMohr for their dedication, hard work & exceptional management of a number of grants. (The members supported this mention with applause)
- HChan confirmed that Cutcher & Neale would continue to be auditing body for the coming year.

FINANCIAL REPORTS – Accepted**Proposed: CJordan****Seconded: AMarendy****7. ELECTION OF BOARD:*****11 vacancies to fill on the Board******16 Nominations for the 2010 NSS Board include:***

- i. Henry Chan
- ii. Rachele Dos Santos
- iii. Christine Jordan
- iv. Irina Lupish
- v. Anna Marendy
- vi. Trudy Mills-Evers
- vii. Renata Ninevski
- viii. Phillip Ross
- ix. Alphanso Sarpur
- x. Carla Silva
- xi. William Simanowsky
- xii. Lola Sklavos
- xiii. Biko Syongoh
- xiv. Zoran Vasiljevic
- xv. Sania Young
- xvi. Fthr Nicholas Zervas

Returning Officer – Cr Nuatali Nemes (NCC)**Scrutineer 1** - Zachary Ekandi**Scrutineer 2** – Sr Betty Brown

▪ (1.10pm) **Directors duly elected to the Board:**

- i. **Henry Chan**
- ii. **Christine Jordan**
- iii. **William Simanowsky**
- iv. **Irina Lupish**
- v. **Trudy Mills-Evers**
- vi. **Biko Syongoh**
- vii. **Zoran Vasiljevic**
- viii. **Sania Young**
- ix. **Carla Silva**
- x. **Fthr N Zervas**
- xi. **Anna Marendy**

8. GENERAL BUSINESS:

- NSS to sponsor a TAFE award – name to be decided
- HChan thanked members for their attendance

MEETING CLOSED 1.15pm

ATTENDANCE – AGM 2009

	Name	Organisation/Group
1.	Lola Sklavos	NSS Board Member
2.	Nina Zervas	NSS Member
3.	Rev. Nicholas Zervas	NSS Board Member
4.	Glen Peterkin	Cutcher & Neale
5.	Sania Young	NSS Board Member
6.	Sandra Wingrave	NSS Staff – CC
7.	Pari Batha	NSS Staff – CC
8.	Trudy Wahl	NSS Staff – CC
9.	C. Jordan	NSS Board Member
10.	W. Simanowsky	NSS Board Member
11.	Danielle Habib	NSS Staff – CC
12.	Denise Hodgson	Centrelink
13.	Henry Chan	NSS Board Member
14.	Trudy Mills-Evers	NSS Board Member
15.	Phillip Ross	PCYC
16.	Elena Ferguson	NSS Staff
17.	Angelina Filchokova	TAFE Student
18.	Zenaida Edmunds	NSS Staff
19.	Nellie Srisurapon	NSS Staff
20.	Wendy Kirkham	NSS Staff
21.	Alex Burns	NSS Staff
22.	Irina Lupish	Russian Community
23.	Sue Hristov	NSS Staff
24.	Marianne Mohr	NSS Staff – Accounts
25.	Lupe Fonua	NSS Staff
26.	Olivia Graham	NSS Staff
27.	Arlene Richards	NSS Staff – Accounts
28.	Rose Oku	NSS Staff
29.	Anna Bailey	NSS Member
30.	Zachary Ekandi	TAFE
31.	Sister Betty	Penola House
32.	Cr Nuatali Nelmes	NCC
33.	Josephine Ekezie	
34.	Flora Aine	NSS Staff
35.	Anna Marendy	NSS Board Member
36.	Mary Milevski	NSS Staff
37.	Tima Oto	NSS Staff
38.	Finau Manu	NSS Staff
39.	Renata Ninevski	DET
40.	Lulu Tantos	NSS Staff

ATTENDANCE CONTINUED – AGM 2009

41.	Helen Buchanan	NSS Staff
42.	Enza Di Stefano	NSS Staff
43.	Mohamed Kamara	NSS Staff
44.	Carla Silva	HNE Health
45.	Michael Freund	NSS Staff
46.	Kiri Hata	NSS Staff
47.	Rachele Dos Santos	Italian Community
48.	Helen Short	NSS Staff
49.	Biko Syongoh	NSS Board Member
50.	Pet Kelly	NSS Staff
51.	Juanita Loli	NSS Staff
52.	Paul Marendy	Member
53.	Val Woodman	NSS Staff
54.	Amer Manyoun	NSS Staff

APOLOGIES – AGM 2009

	Name	Organisation/Group
1.	Olivia Fuente	NSS Staff
2.	Silvia Ruano-McClerie	NSS Staff
3.	Zoran Vasiljevic	NSS Board Member
4.	Miza Torlakovic	NSS Staff
5.	Richard Hardy	NSS Staff
6.	Alphanso Sarpur	Nominee

Overview of 2010

Funding Partnerships

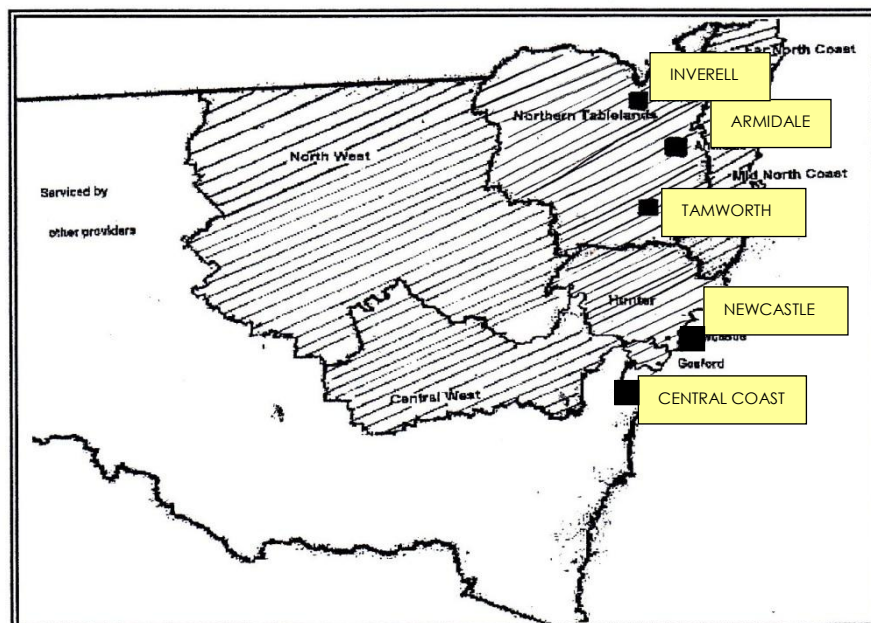
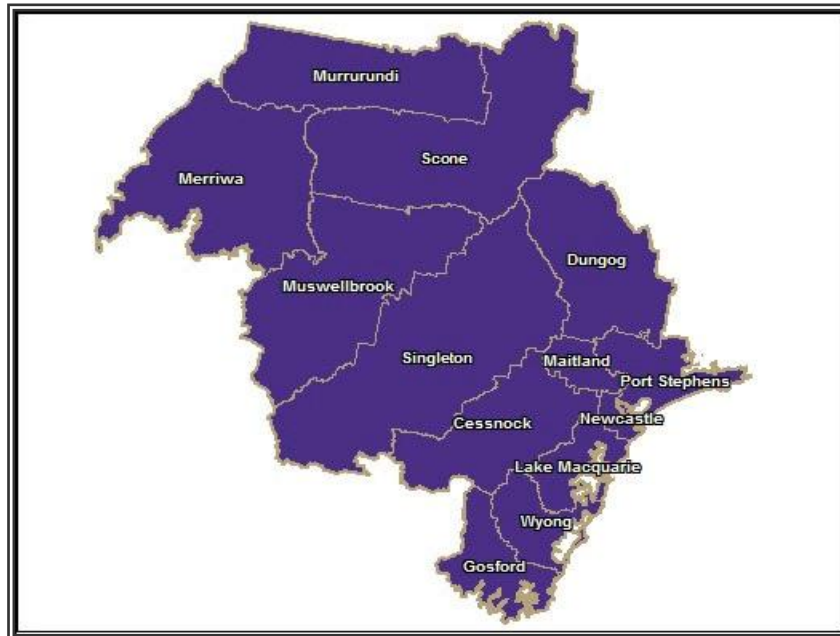
-  Department of Immigration & Citizenship (DIAC)
-  Department of Human Services, Community Services Agency
-  Commonwealth Department of Health & Ageing
-  NSW Department of Ageing Disability & Home Care (DADHC)
-  Community Development Support Expenditure (Registered Clubs NSW)
-  Department of Families & Housing, Community Services & Indigenous Affairs (FaHCSIA)

Clients by Ethnic Background

Afghanistan	Fiji	Liberia	Senegal
Albania	Finland	Malaysia	Serbia
Algeria	France	Mauritania	Slovenia
Argentina	Germany	Montenegro	Sierra Leone
Australia	Greece	Macedonia	Singapore
Austria	Guatemala	Mexico	Somalia
Bangladesh	Honduras	Morocco	South Africa
Bosnia	Hungary	Nepal	Sri Lanka
Botswana	Hong Kong	Netherlands	Spain
Brazil	India	New Zealand	Sudan
Burundi	Indonesia	Nigeria	Sweden
Canada	Ireland	Norway	Switzerland
Chile	Iran	Panama	Syria
China	Iraq	Pakistan	Tahiti
Colombia	Italy	Papua New Guinea	Taiwan
Congo (DRC)	Japan	Paraguay	Thailand
Croatia	Jordan	Peru	Tonga
Cyprus	Kazakhstan	Poland	Turkey
Czech Republic	Kenya	Portugal	Ukraine
Dominican Republic	Korea	Philippines	Uruguay
East Timor	Kuwait	Romania	USA
Egypt	Lebanon	Russia	Vietnam
El Salvador	Latvia	Rwanda	Venezuela
England	Lithuania	Scotland	Zimbabwe

OFFICE LOCATIONS & SERVICE REGIONS

HUNTER OUTREACH



Areas serviced by NSS offices & Outreach workers



Chairman's Report

Henry Chan OAM

I do not believe that in all my years as Chairman of this splendid organisation I have ever witnessed a bleaker period in the public domain for the people who constitute multicultural Australia,- refugees and migrants, the people we have proudly served for the 29 years since our establishment .

This last year has truly represented a new low in the way our country's leaders, on both sides of politics, appear to view our constituents- and that means us! For we are all migrants and refugees here and we are all touched by the way the issues important to us have been ignored at best and demonised at worst. How well described by the recent public debate between our two major parties about immigration and refugee intakes as "a race to the bottom." And as the debate has become louder and more shrill, we are struck by the deafening silence of the policies of access and equity that used to keep the bureaucracies accountable.

When I reflect on it- what a modest wish list we have been bringing to the table for what seems like forever. Just a handful of fairly basic recognitions – that our newcomers are welcome to Australia, that their settlement in this country is an investment worth supporting, and that the multiculturalism on which Australia is built has brought enormous value to the social, cultural and economic life of this country. Yes, even despite the Global Financial Crisis! Despite this unedifying landscape, however, we power on, striving all the harder to assist our newcomers to settle in this country, to integrate harmoniously with those already here, and through active participation in this way of life to continue to demonstrate how much is value- added to the Australian nation. Peruse this Report, my friends, and judge for yourselves.

We are also of the view that it is time for our organisation itself to put down permanent roots in the area where we have made our mark. Plans are afoot for NSS to purchase its own headquarters which can serve as a stable and long term base for our current and future programmes. It is an exciting time for us organisationally, but it is also very fitting that I pay homage to the work of those of our senior management staff for the solid financial situation that makes the purchase of a building possible. These people saw our organisation through the very fragile times when, to put it bluntly, the Department of Immigration cut us loose by removing the core funding that it had hitherto accorded its Migrant Resource Centres.

With hindsight the Department did us a favour-but only because of those astute and forward thinking people we were lucky enough to have on staff.

And in 2010, two of them are saying their farewells.

Arlene Richards, book keeper extraordinaire, is off to do the many other clever things that she has been planning.

Our longest serving staff member and our CEO, Violetta Walsh, is also taking well earned leave with a view to retirement. She leaves with a remarkable record of 26 years of dedicated service to this agency and its people, an example of true dedication, and a role model whose shoes will not be easy to fill. Her stepping down is truly the end of an era, the like of which we will not see again.

I would like to acknowledge also the loyalty and dedication of all the wonderful personnel who are part of the good ship NSS, its Board, its staff and its volunteers. My sincere thanks to all of you for the wonderful work you do to make this world a better place.



Chief Executive Officer's Report

Violetta Walsh OAM

This report is frankly going to be something of a jumble, part retrospective, part philosophising, a little less succinct than usual, but perhaps I can be forgiven. Whatever other involvements I may continue to have with this wonderful organisation, this is my last report as its CEO. Mind you, in my heart of hearts I have not moved much beyond the rank of Coordinator that was the original title of the "boss cocky" of the outfit, way back in 1984. (Yes, **that** year, of literary fame and dread, and whatever it was supposed to do, it did actually change my life.)

Luckily, I am prescribed by space, so what I offer is just a skim across the surface of the time I have spent in this place, which I could describe in all sorts of ways. "Boring" is not one of them.

They were halcyon days, the early 80's. In the space of a few months I moved from a placid and happy enough existence as a housewife and mother to a very different, even public, sort of role. After a short period with the then Ethnic Affairs Commission, I took up the job of running the very new Migrant Resource Centre (comprising then just 2 other souls) which had been created by the Commonwealth Government to help newcomers settle into their new homeland. And it's still worth noting that it was a conservative federal government that can take the kudos for this most beneficial and positive initiative.

And so it began, this journey, and the growing, bit by bit, until I find myself, in 2010, the accidental CEO of an operation that involves the employment of over 40 staff in several locations and various capacities, over 200 volunteers, and the delivery of settlement and assorted other welfare services to the thousands of migrants and refugees settled in the regions north of the Sydney metropolitan area.

But not to get too carried away- NSS is still, at its core, a modest and very grass roots show. It just punches above its weight. It has from the start and will while ever it lives and breathes.

Please just take the time to consider the reports that our agency staff have prepared, which detail the depth and extent of the services that Northern Settlement Services delivers these days, the settlement services, the family support services, the community development, the aged care, the migration advice and assistance etc etc.

The sheer volume of contact in our Hamilton office alone through our small extraordinarily hard working reception area is amazing, with statistics recording close to 30,000 contacts in the course of the year, in person, by phone and electronically.

We actually practice that elusive activity of “social inclusion” that we keep hearing a great deal about from Government. I don't know how it's supposed to work, but I am confident that our agency actually does include all possible client groups in our service delivery, whether at Board level, in our staff membership, and of course in the clients we serve, whether newly arrived, or long settled, old and young, all drawn from every continent of this planet.

That makes me very proud, this inclusiveness. If there is any legacy I want to leave, it is that the organisation that I have been responsible for, has never knowingly discriminated, but has shown welcome and value to all the cultural and ethnic groups with whom it has had the pleasure and privilege to be involved.

But it is quite surreal to think that I have managed to clock up so many years in this establishment. My mind is brimming with the memories, and my heart with the variety of emotions as I take a step as life changing as that step I took 26 and a half years ago when I signed up.

I will spare you the emotions and the memories –though there has to be a book in it somewhere! But I will share with you a handful of the learnings that I have made in the course of this long and unforgettable ride.

I have learnt that this migrant and refugee settlement industry (in my view, more aptly described as a vocation- or even passion) is more politicised than just about any other I can think of. It is hard enough just trying to help people in need without having to worry about whether, this year, as opposed to last year, or next year, your target group and your service, and everything you believe in, are in or out of political favour; and assess whether you are to be cast as an apologist, an advocate, a demon, or a saint. Or whether you can simply be what you put your hand up to be, an enabler, a helper, a support for people in need.

I have also, and pretty obviously, learnt that we cannot work in silos in human services. Not rocket science to engage with as many mainstream providers as possible- charities, churches, not for profits, government departments, private providers (even!) to ensure that our clients are truly well served. The MRC, or the NSS was never intended to be all things to the people it was established to serve.

I have learnt that successful integration of our new Australians is very much a two way exercise – where neither the host nor the newcomer should be spooked, where each understands what is expected of the other, and each respects and values the other.

Hardest of all, I have come to believe that, for some individuals and communities, integration is simply too hard, now or ever. This new homeland asks more than they are prepared to give in accommodation with our norms, our laws, our codes of social behaviour and interaction. If we want to have harmony, collaboration and compromise in this country going forward, we need to invest in a clear and unambiguous program of orientation for those we accept into this country, where we spell out what is negotiable and what is not.

We must avoid the tragic acknowledgement of Chancellor Merkel of West Germany, that, 60 years after the event, multiculturalism in her country has not worked. It has worked in ours, but we need to be vigilant to ensure it continues.

On a more personal level I have learnt that compassion is not a bottomless well, that we all need and deserve a little glimmer of responsiveness from our clients. It is nice when the "cared for" actually care back.

And of course I have learnt that nobody can go on forever, no matter how much you love what you do.

As I said before, I am brimming with memories, and they are mainly of the people who have enriched my life, made me think, made me cry, made me laugh, inspired me, made me a better person. How blest I have been that our paths have crossed, how blest I am that I can count some of them as friends, who will remain so even when my role here is done.

Finally, as always, my thanks to the Board of this organisation whose support over the years has been quite extraordinary and one especially who has been with me virtually since the beginning. To the staff, my other family, I will miss you more than I can say.

SPECIAL PROJECTS TEAM

Ms Violetta Walsh
Chief Executive Officer
Special Projects Team Leader

Ms Lulu Tantos
Deputy Chief Executive Officer
Registered Migration Agent

Mr Richard Hardy
Registered Migration Agent

Ms Kiri Hata
Complex Case Support (CCS) Coordinator



Immigration Advice & Assistance Scheme

Lulu Tantos (Reg.#0318123) & **Richard Hardy** (Reg.#9473161)

Funded by Department of Immigration & Citizenship

Northern Settlement Services Ltd (NSS) continues to provide quality immigration advice and assistance to clients in Newcastle, the Hunter Region and its catchment area.

In the last year the service has with great regret seen a turnover of staff, with the retirement of Irina Lupish whose skills and experience in this specialised area of work, I wish to acknowledge, are sorely missed.

This year the service has been maintained and provided by Deputy CEO Lulu Tantos and Richard Hardy, who joined us on a contractual basis in October 2009 and whose contribution over the year has been truly valued. I would also like to acknowledge the administrative contribution given to the project by Silvia Ruano-McLerie who too has 'retired' her position with us to take on an even more demanding role as 'mother' to her new baby girl.

I am happy to report, however, that the service will be augmented by the arrival of a new worker, Olivia Fuente, from our Central Coast office, who is herself a registered migration agent, in November 2010. We welcome her to the team and look forward with her assistance to maintaining this valuable service at NSS.

As in previous years, the service has been provided to two distinct client groups:

- IAAAS (Immigration Advice & Application Assistance Scheme) eligible clients; and
- Fee paying clients

NSS is one of 23 DIAC (Department of Immigration and Citizenship) funded IAAAS providers around Australia providing professional assistance, free of charge, to the most vulnerable and needy visa applicants, to help with the completion and submission of visa applications, liaison with the department, and advice on complex immigration matters.

Persons eligible for Application Assistance include all protection visa applicants in detention, and the most disadvantaged protection visa applicants and other visa applicants in the community. Advice sessions are designed for disadvantaged visa applicants, prospective visa applicants or sponsors in the community.

What counts as disadvantage?

A 'Disadvantaged Person' is one who is in financial hardship and disadvantaged due to:

- non-English speaking background, youth, or other cultural issues such as gender barriers preventing assistance;
- illiteracy in main language of country of origin;
- remote location;
- physical or psychological disability, including from past torture or trauma; or
- physical or psychological harm resulting from family violence.

The scheme has provided advice and assistance to 296 eligible clients.

In addition to the IAAAS the past year has seen the provision of quality, professional services on over 300 occasions to clients from culturally diverse backgrounds such as China, the Philippines, the Sudan, Thailand, Russia, India, Korea, and Liberia. Over 1000 telephone enquiries have been fielded and advice and assistance provided in a range of visa classes, both temporary and permanent.

Throughout the year the service has been complemented by quarterly outreach visits to the office by experienced Officers from the DIAC Parramatta Office. This service has been invaluable in providing clients in our region with the opportunity to meet and discuss face-to-face their specific needs with a Departmental Officer. Initiated in 1996 as a result of the closure of the local immigration office it continues today and we are most grateful for the support and assistance the Officers from Parramatta provide to our staff and clients. We look forward to maintaining a close working relationship with them in the future.

To the Board of Management and to our colleagues thank you for your continued dedication to our cause and for your support and guidance throughout the year.

To Violetta, well you know how I feel.....



Complex Case Support (CCS)

Kiri Hata

Funded by Department of Immigration & Citizenship

Background

The Department of Immigration and Citizenship funds a contract service for Complex Case Support and NSS is the local service provider.

It is designed to assist new or recently arrived refugee clients experiencing extreme hardship and disadvantage in their settlement, above and beyond the more routine services which all refugees have on arrival in this country. The program provides for a level of critical intervention for the most needy, to enable those barriers they face to be addressed as a matter of urgency and for strategies to be developed that will enable them to return to the business of settling in this region.

Program Issues and Responses

Clients in this program are often facing multiple issues at the same time, from legal matters as victims or perpetrators, insecure or inappropriate housing, financial stress, Centrelink benefits being withheld or ceased, elevated physical and psychological health needs, difficulties around child and adult education, domestic violence situations, facing DoCS intervention and requiring assistance with alternative parenting strategies.

Support is provided to individuals and families through a range of means. These can include interagency casework meetings to agree strategies; family conferencing; support through court processes and arranging access to legal advice; facilitating parent meetings with schools; assistance negotiating access for medical services; linking clients into community support networks for day to day needs; and working with a team of staff and volunteers to work on urgent housing or welfare issues. Sometimes, all of these services were required for one client family.

Various NSS programs are utilised and casework support for those matters that fall under existing programs is provided by staff working with families, young children and with the Refugee Support Team. Volunteer support is mobilized through the volunteer coordinators, with in-home tutoring, shopping and transport assistance, one-to-one mentoring, etc. Two families remain linked to the DoCS Brighter Futures program, and several others have been referred.

Referrals to this program come from within NSS (other programs) and external agencies such as STARTTS, Centrelink and Department of Community Services.

Our contract was due for completion in August, 2010, but was extended to mid-2011 to enable a full review of the program to be undertaken by DIAC.

Statistics

Contracts in place at the start of the period:	6
Contracts accepted during the period:	8
Contracts completed during the period:	12

Total client numbers during the period:

Families:	14
Males:	6
Females:	11
Children:	44

Conclusion

This program allows us to put the focus on specific clients and greatly improve the outcomes for the most disadvantaged of our client group. We work closely with many other agencies, and see the benefit of interagency case management of specific families, with NSS taking the lead role and ensuring best practice and timely intervention.

Clients are delighted with the relationships developed and support given under CCS and believe they have been empowered and a party in their own success in dealing with the issues they have faced. The increased resources available to achieve these outcomes have also ensured the general services of the centre are not undermined due to the high needs and complexity of service delivery.

It has also been necessary to work closely with others to ensure record keeping standards required by the contract are maintained. There has also been complexity and much work in managing every case as a separate contract.

I have found this work to be most rewarding, the work environment dynamic and exciting, and am grateful for the full support, advice and encouragement of the management and administrative teams.

RURAL TEAM

Mr Alex Burns
Team Leader
Rural Support Project

Ms Rose Oku
Hunter Welfare Outreach Settlement Support (SGP) Worker

Ms Judith Roberts
Armidale Settlement Support (SGP) Worker
(New England)

Mr Amalin Sundarevej
Tamworth Settlement Support (SGP) Worker
(New England)

Ms Mary Prendergast *(til May 2010)* / **Ms Katie Wright**
Inverell Settlement Support (SGP) Worker
(New England)



Rural Support Settlement Grants Program

Alex Burns

Funded by Department of Immigration & Citizenship
- Settlement Grant Program (SGP)

Introduction

This project provides team leadership, assistance, mentoring and resourcing to NSS and other rural DIAC funded SGP projects who provide support to highly disadvantaged new arrival refugees, family and other permanent visa holders and may be experiencing hardship through isolation, domestic violence, homelessness, mental health and other misfortunes in their settlement in the regional areas of northern and western NSW.

Support is varied and is provided to projects in a range of diverse locations on the North Coast (Lismore and Coffs Harbour); Mid North Coast (Manning Valley and Port Macquarie); New England (Armidale, Tamworth and Inverell); Central Western and Far Western (Orange, Bathurst and Dubbo); Central Coast and in the Hunter Region including Newcastle.

Achievements

Casework and Orientation Support

As this project backs up other projects to support their casework and also provides some direct casework Table 1 provides information on this and other project work as recorded in DIAC's Online Settlement Client Activity Recording (OSCAR) work

Table 1: OSCARs for the Rural Support Grant 2009-10

Clients	Case Contacts	Short Contacts	Group Sessions
36	53	12205	60

A brief snapshot of the project's clientele and their issues shows that nearly 60 percent of those supported were from refugee or humanitarian background. Most lived in regional areas and in particular the New England region. Their issues were diverse but those relating to legal problems, family relationships and those around community development made up the bulk of the work. 86 percent were helped after 1-2 contacts with the average time spent with most contacts being between 30-60 minutes. As would be expected most client origins were from African with Dinka Sudanese and Congolese making up the largest groups given support by this project.

Direct Work with Rural Based Projects

While the SGP projects have great competencies with their casework sometimes strategies are required with specific clients to address major problems. This project counsels and mentors, advising project workers on how to best address these types of problems. Issues like the lack of services using interpreters in their dealings with our client target group and the problems this continues to have for our clients are the areas where this project's skills and advice on casework are mostly provided. Contact and support to the individual rural based SGP projects comprises visits and regular phone contact and more and more through the use of emails. The nature of the visits vary with each project with some of the work reflecting the individual need while in other instances relates to the team leader responsibilities with NSS SGP projects. As will be seen from Table 2 the largest number of visits was to the NSS managed projects, and this included the project's Rural Team Leader role for NSS. The year saw SGP project workers change in Inverell, in Manning Valley and on the Central Coast, while the Dubbo SGP project worker suffered a serious illness.

Table 2: Face to Face Visits to Regional and Rural SGP Projects

SGP Location	Visits	SGP Location	Visits
Wyoming/Central Coast	10	Tamworth	12
Inverell	7	Armidale	10
Manning Valley	6	Lismore	2
Hunter Outreach	12	African Communities	8
Dubbo	2	Orange	3
Bathurst	3	Coffs Harbour	4
African Youth	6	Homework Centres	3

Individual project issues included new project worker selection, setting in place appropriate accountability measures with this last issue being a major one that I tend to stress with every SGP project, competition with other services, work around events and funding.

Other Work

This project continues to convene or support the strong Multicultural Forums that exist. This has included raising with government and non-government agencies specific issues such as inclusion of rural health in the proposed NSW Refugee Health plan, arranging speakers to talk on matters of concern like the Complex Case program with DIAC, and heightening the profile of the Migrant and Refugee target group through sharing of information and identifying trends attributed to this group. These forums support the work of NSS and the SGP projects to raise their profiles, have other services become aware of their responsibilities and present on their service operations. The project also participates in other forums to gain information on services and referral process and in planning and policy development. Altogether, a busy but productive year.



Hunter Welfare Outreach Settlement Grants Program Rose Oku

Funded by Department of Immigration & Citizenship
- Settlement Grant Program (SGP)

The Hunter Welfare Outreach SGP project provides support services to highly disadvantaged new arrival refugees and migrants, especially women who are experiencing hardship through isolation, domestic violence, homelessness and other misfortunes encountered in their settlement.

Casework

During the year (2009-2010) the project provided face to face casework for the client group and especially in the provision of support for women in isolated parts of the Hunter. The Hunter project has continued to support clients assisting them to attend Family Court, to access English and employment training courses, Centrelink, community health programs and tenancy services.

531 Client Contacts were addressed in 2009-2010. The average length of time spent with clients was 45 minutes. Clients presented a wide range of issues, including: Family Relations, Health, Legal, Material and Financial Assistance. Table 1 provides a picture of this work which shows the distribution of the client base over the Hunter region. The table shows the number of clients the project supported in each location.

Table 1: Casework: Top 20 Post Codes of Clients Residences 2009-2010

LOCATION	NUMBER OF CLIENTS
Singleton	40
Belmont	31
Cessnock	31
Charlestown	20
Nelson Bay	14
Abermain	13
Raymond Terrace	11
Speers Point	10
Shoal Bay	6
Maitland	6
Kurri Kurri	6
Meadowie	4
Toronto	3
Warners Bay	2
Anna Bay	2
Tanilba Bay	2
Tomago	2
Greta	2

208 clients were served individually while other issues arose within group work similar to those above.

Group Work

Multicultural Friendship Groups are now based in different locations, in Singleton, Cessnock, Port Stephens, and Maitland. A proposed group is to be established in Lake Macquarie.



29 Information sessions were held throughout the year in partnership with other services like Community Health and Centrelink. These sessions were held to address, women's health, education, family relationships, and immigration issues. A pool of volunteers was also developed from the client group.

- The Multicultural Groups from each location participated in community events and celebrations. For example Living In Harmony Day was celebrated in 4 locations; Singleton; Cessnock, Maitland and Port Stephens with over 50 participants attending each event.
- Refugee Week was celebrated throughout the Hunter and Port Stephens area with the client group participating in schools and council events. At each event, the group received recognition and further invitations to raise cultural awareness in the community.
- The Port Stephens Group has successfully applied and received funding for Living in Harmony Celebrations 2011.

Networking and other Forums

The success of the project has been due to its capacity to network with other organisations and 19 inter-agencies and other meetings were attended through the year. The project worker was able to share information on the target group, refer sensitive case work to familiar services and to develop a strong base on issues that impacted on the new arrival clients.

4 meetings of the Hunter Rural Multicultural Network were held. At these meetings speakers were arranged and in Maitland, Council presented its Social Plan to improve service delivery to the migrant community in the Maitland area.

Other networking occurred with local inter-agencies participation at Lake Macquarie, Port Stephens, Cessnock, Upper Hunter and Singleton.

Training

The project worker continued to develop skills to help the target group. 13 training sessions were attended including DIAC training, Staff planning days, DoCS training, and with forums presented by Energy Australia and the Family Law conference.

Finally, it has been a busy year with good outcomes for the project's refugee and migrant client group.



New England Settlement Grants Program (Armidale) Judith Roberts

Funded by Department of Immigration & Citizenship
- Settlement Grant Program (SGP)

The Armidale project continues to provide settlement information, referrals to other agencies, community capacity building, service planning and development to new arrivals, including migrants and humanitarian entrants, and the dependents of skilled migrants. The client groups most represented are humanitarian entrants who are single parents with large families, single men and an emerging group are the wives of young refugee men who have returned to their home countries to marry. These clients required intensive settlement support and had some very good outcomes. Many clients have been distressed around family members still in Africa who they would like to propose.

Table 1 Client Statistics

OSCAR 1	OSCAR 2	OSCAR 3	OSCAR 4
37	1260	6,677	127

Client Services

Client issues identified include: accommodation, family relationships/ breakdowns, access to mental health support, Centrelink, employment, transport, debt issues, access to driving lessons, and health access mainly due to transport problems and lack of knowledge of the health system, homework support, access and equity, access to childcare. The main client group are Humanitarian 202 visa holders and migrants on spouse visas. Many of the women face the added challenges as sole parents due to their husband's return to the country of origin, death, or family breakdown. The SGP, often in collaboration with Sanctuary Armidale, continues to meet the needs of families. The young men's issues are employment, access to driving lessons, housing, and access to education and training. Despite this, in 2010 the employment situation for many Refugees has improved with secondary settlers, as well as the local community having found work in industries such as the Guyra Tomato Farm, Aged Care and contract cleaning. The project works with Job Networks such as Advanced Personnel Management and has worked closely with other agencies such as the Commonwealth rehabilitation Service to support clients. Another client group regularly seen is the language class at TAFE. The project supports the attendance at AMEP and LLNP of all the relevant target group.

Many of our target group have been supported into stable accommodation through private rentals or through public and community housing. There have been many, many excellent outcomes for the target group and the end of 2009 saw the graduation of Sudanese students at the University of New England across a range of disciplines.

Homework Support

NSS commenced Homework Support during 2009 in collaboration with Sanctuary Armidale and Armidale Dumaresq Council, to a group of Primary age pupils. This was very well received and in 2010 DET funded a Coordinating teacher and provided the venue at Drummond Memorial School. One student and attendee at HW Support was selected in the Primary Schools Basketball Championships in Darwin and was presented with a Silver Medal for his achievements.

Information Sessions

A highlight of 2009 was an information session to the Armidale Hospital's Children's Ward for parents and children. Afterwards Santa visited, courtesy of the Armidale Fire Services. In 2010, the project worked with the Refugee Health Nurse to present a series of Health information sessions. The topics ranged from 'Accessing Interpreters' to 'Family Medicine and Family Nutrition'. The sessions were well attended and interpreters were provided by Health. Women mainly attended, although a couple of the sessions, the first 'Navigating the Australian Health System'- attracted men as well.

Meetings and Committee representation

The project is involved in a range of networks including NE Multicultural Health Access Committee, DET Equity, Refugee Student Support, Armidale Interagency, Sanctuary Armidale and the New England Multicultural Interagency. The project also works closely with Health and supports the health needs of our target group and the work that STARTTS counsellors undertake. The mental health wellbeing of the Refugee community is supported by the project and all other concerned services and makes a real difference to the quality of lives to new and longer term migrants and refugees.

Refugee Week Events

The highlight of Refugee Week Celebrations this year was the Armidale Dumaresq Mayor's Morning Tea. Mayor Ducat commended the refugees present for their continuing commitment to the Armidale community and also thanked those who welcome and support refugees. Mr Peter Georkas a Refugee from Cyprus and Mrs Ding Dut both made heartfelt speeches that reinforced how fortunate we were to welcome Refugees to our city. The project has been able to promote and liaise with all concerned to make these Refugee Week events and projects the wonderful success they have been.

Summary

Each year there are many wonderful achievements for the SGP target group to reflect on and this year, 2010, is no exception. New arrivals have found safety and success in their new homes tempered by the sadness of separation from their loved ones left behind. The work of the SGP in Armidale is a link for the CALD community that enables new settlers, many of who are from very traumatic backgrounds, to find worthwhile and sustaining lives in the Australian community.



New England Settlement Grants Program (Tamworth)

Amalin Sundaravej

Funded by Department of Immigration & Citizenship
- Settlement Grant Program (SGP)

The Tamworth New England Settlement Grant Project (SGP) provides support services to highly disadvantaged new arrival refugees, family and other permanent resident visa holders who have low English language proficiency. Clients experience hardship through isolation, domestic violence, homelessness, mental health and other issues.

The Tamworth project has also addressed the lack of supportive networks, assisting the refugee and migrant community's development and promoting a sense of self identity, belonging and participation with the broader Tamworth community. It also raises awareness among the mainstream service providers to assist them to become more responsive to needs of the target group in the Tamworth area.

Overview of 2009-2010

Table 1: Client Contact & Project Work: 2009-2010

OSCAR 1	OSCAR 2	OSCAR 3	OSCAR 4
36	198	3631	43

The 198 client OSCAR 2 contacts in Table 1, covered a range of issues including: citizenship, housing, employment, health, education and training. In supporting the clients, referrals were made to: Centrelink, NSW Housing, Law Access, North Northwest Community Legal Service, Legal Aid, Immigration Rights Centre and Trades Recognition Australia and so on.

Table 2 is a summary of the clients by background who have been assisted by the project. As will be noted the vast number of the client group were people from the Philippines who have settled as spouses. However the second largest group are people from Sudan, refugees who have sought work in the industries found in Tamworth or have wanted a better environment for their children. One problem for the Africans has been a difficulty in obtaining rental accommodation and they have not been able to bring their family into Tamworth to live with them. Likewise, they have been limited in their choice of housing.

Table 2: Clients by Background (according to birthplace)

Background of Clients	Number	Background of Clients	Number
Sudanese	8	British	1
Zimbabwean	4	Indonesian	2
Filipino	27	Vietnamese	2
Thai	2	Nepali	1
Indian (So. Asia)	3	Afghani	1
Turkish	1	Singaporean	1
Nigerian	4	Somali	1
Egyptian	1	Ghanaian	1
Maltese	2	TOTAL	62

Employment Opportunities

In Tamworth, employment opportunities for our target group is more towards the low skills area like the abattoirs and chicken processing plants which are the two major sources of employment that continue to attract the African (male) community to the area as well as the new male migrants. Other migrant communities, and especially Filipino women are employed more widely in chicken hatchery plants, egg picking and packing. A few women have now obtained aged care certificates and are now employed on a casual or part-time basis.

Those with overseas professional skills have difficulty in finding acceptance in the workplace and tend to resort to the low skill employment such as labouring. This is due to the language barriers, lack of or no recognition of their skills in Australia until it's been assessed, which is an expensive and lengthy process. As mentioned earlier, although these migrants are educated, their fluency in the English language communication skills is still limited and it is a big hindrance and also a barrier in their search for appropriate employment.

Networking

During the reporting period, the SGP contacts and networks have vastly improved and these served to improve NSS links as a better and more responsive and service provider. New membership in other networks included the New England Multicultural Interagency group, the Transcultural Rural and Remote Outreach Project Consortium, Tamworth Family Support Services Network, Tamworth Family Pathways Network, Centrelink Empowerment Providers Network.

NSS Tamworth has been actively involved in promoting issues and awareness on multicultural issues as evident of its active participation during Harmony Day celebrations and the Refuge Week event which has been well documented through good coverage in all media such as newspapers, television and radio.



New England Settlement Grants Program (Inverell)

Katie Wright

Funded by Department of Immigration & Citizenship
- Settlement Grant Program (SGP)

The Inverell project provides a support service to refugees and family stream migrants within the local area, primarily, providing settlement information and orientation, capacity building and social integration. Referrals to main stream service providers have been vital and a strong relationship has ensured that services are accessible and equitable to the client group.

Client Services

The client group originate from Africa, Pacific Islands and Asia and have a diverse range of issues. These included, but were not limited to the following: employment, special educational needs, health, social participation, isolation from main family group, transportation and learning to drive.

Network and Community Relations

Participation and attendance of community meetings has been essential in building the ongoing relationship between the project and other service providers. Meetings regularly attended have included Sanctuary, Inverell Interagency, Inverell Anti-Violence Committee, Love Bites Committee, DOCS, Inverell Youth Issues and the New England Multicultural Interagency.

The project has been involved in the 'You Can Stop the Violence' Campaign which complimented Inverell's 'Anti-Social Behaviour is not OK' Campaign. In association with the Inverell Anti-Violence Committee I supported the Inverell White Ribbon Ball through coordinating this event. This raised awareness around the issues of violence in our community and to raised funds towards establishing a Youth Centre in Inverell. The promotion surrounding the Ball was huge and NSS gained considerable 'air time' on both the local and commercial radio stations. Several feature articles and various adverts were also in the local Inverell newspaper.

Community Events

A highlight of the year was participation in the Sapphire City Festival, held in October 2009. 35 people boarded The NSS float, 'Celebrating Culture in Inverell' for the ride through the town. Nationalities were well represented including, Sudanese, Congolese, Fijian, Tongan, Filipino and Vietnamese. The float received amazing support from the local community. Inverell Freighters provided the Semi-Trailer and a driver, Platypus Pre-School decorated the truck and McNeil's Hire provided balloons. Everyone involved had a fantastic time and it left me feeling extremely proud of what we had achieved.





Inverell celebrated Refugee Week 2010 with a tree planting ceremony in Campell Park. A native gum tree was donated, Inverell Council prepared the site and the local Girl Guides provided a venue for morning tea. 50 people representing various services, schools and other community organisations came to celebrate the day. A highlight for the event was our local refugee community members proudly shining on the front of the local paper the following week.

The final stages of the 'Freedom from Fear' Photographic Exhibition were also completed and submitted to be a part of an upcoming book.

Programme Development

The Inverell Migrant Network (IMN) was established in 2009 and meets at minimum once a month. The meetings have featured various information sessions on health and employment. A goal has been the proposed development of an IMN Market Stall, selling craft items and gifts made by the women themselves. The diversity of skill and creativity within the group is wonderful and everyone is hoping this will be a beneficial and skill building experience.

Throughout the year the IMN has participated in several outings and events. Many ladies helped with the decoration of the 'Celebration of Culture in Inverell' float and spent a morning at Platypus Pre-School painting and colouring with the children.

Highlights of our activities have included meeting with the ladies group from Armidale and having morning tea at the Sapphire Tea Gardens in Inverell and also a Christmas Party in Central Park, Armidale.



Newsletter



The New England Rural Team Newsletter was first published in October of 2009 and has received great reviews and support. The newsletter has provided NSS and other service providers within this field an excellent opportunity to inform, educate and promote to the wider community. Not only has it enhanced the ability of our Rural Team to communicate but it has imparted worth upon the valuable service we provide.

CENTRAL COAST TEAM

Mr Alex Burns
Team Leader

Ms Olivia Fuente
Multicultural Social Support Service Coordinator

Ms Julie Styles
Multicultural Social Support Service (Trainee) Coordinator
Administration Assistant

Ms Anita Trainor
Multicultural Social Support Service Coordinator

Ms Danielle Habib
Central Coast Settlement Support Worker (SGP)

Ms Pari Batha
Central Coast Multicultural Family Support Worker

MsTrudy Wahl *(til Nov 2010)* / **Ms Sharlene Huber**
Office Manager
(no report required)



Multicultural Social Support Service

Julie Styles & Olivia Fuente

Funded by Department of Ageing, Disability & Home Care – Home & Community Care (HACC) Program

The Multicultural Social Support Service project (MSSS) supports CALD people in Wyong & Gosford LGAs who are: frail aged, younger people with a disability, and carers of these people.

MODEL OF SERVICE PROVISION

Volunteers are trained and provide the social support to clients and carers. This support includes: home visits, telephone calls, taking clients to: shopping, banking, to medical appointments etc and supporting clients to attend outings and events, including organised client activity days by the MSSS.

ADMINISTRATION

The following administrative tasks have been undertaken throughout the year.

- Bi-Monthly media releases inform the community about the work of Northern Settlement Services' MSSS, and are also used for the purpose of recruiting new Volunteers and clients. 58 Volunteer application kits were sent out, and as a result 33% of Volunteer applicants found out about the service through service promotion, Expos, followed closely by 13% through Newspapers and Radio, 10% through Staff and existing volunteers.
- Northern Settlement Service's new coloured brochure has been very well received as has the Northern Settlement Services' Central Coast Migrant Services Directory.
- Updating of computers and programmes has also made work related tasks easier.
- The introduction of the Intranet was a welcome addition and very user friendly and a good resource to share information. Addition of two new staff members, Julie Styles: Administration Assistant and Anita Trainor: Coordinator.

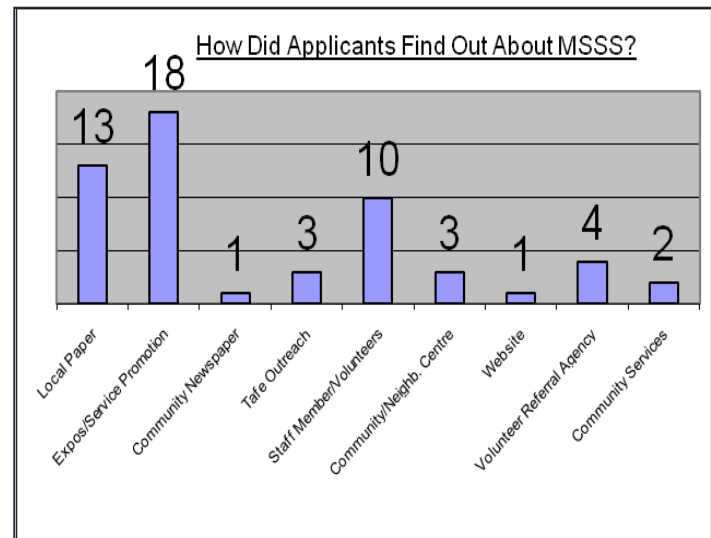
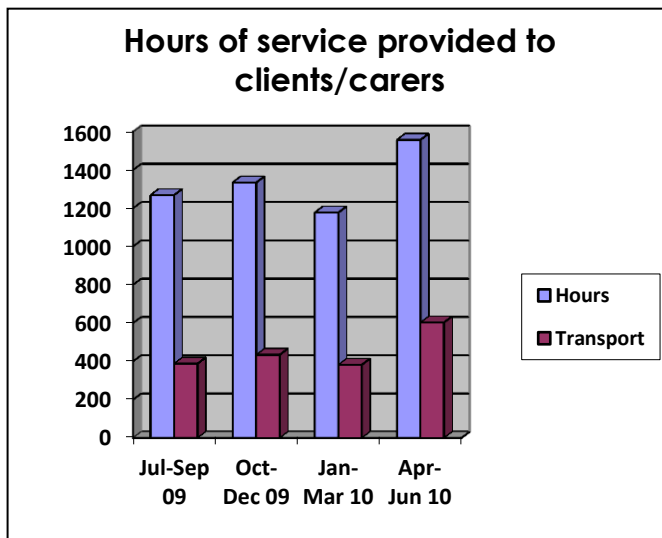
VOLUNTEERS

- To date, the service has 47 registered Volunteers, 39 of whom are actively involved with clients, and of which, 33 speak languages other than English.
- Four Training days and Supervision & Support Meetings have been held throughout the year. Training has included: Cross Cultural Awareness, Brainstorming with Questions & Answers; Low Risk Driving; and Working within Boundaries. Volunteers have also independently attended training provided by the HACC Central Coast including training on an Introduction to Dementia for Volunteers.
- Our number of volunteers has steadily increased throughout 2010.

- Volunteers have continued to assist with transport and activities on our regular monthly client days, including weekly groups in Wyong and the Peninsula as well as providing one on one support.
- Volunteers were given special lunches during National Volunteer Week in May, where we recognised their contribution to the service and also in November, end of the year get-together.

CLIENTS/CARERS

- MSSS provides service to 98 clients and carers. We continue to receive referrals for clients from ACAT, Community Nursing, local hospitals, other community services, word of mouth, self-referrals and from our advertising and promotions.
- Our monthly client group days continue to be popular. This year, the activities have included Indoor Games Day, Fish & Chips at Terrigal Surf Club, Picnic at Toowoona Bay Beach, Lions Club Singer Entertainment, and Lunch at Edogawa Japanese Garden at East Gosford and Christmas Lunch.
- Nationalities represented within our Client/Carer service include Chinese, Polish, Maltese, Singaporean, Filipino, Spanish, Greek, Italian, Austrian, German, Croatian, Finnish, Hungarian, Serbian, Dutch, Fijian, Egyptian, Vietnamese, Uruguayan, Macedonian, Indian, French, Norwegian, Argentinean, Peruvian, South African, Ukrainian, Portuguese, Malaysian, and Cuban.



MSSS PROMOTION 2009 - 2010

CC Multicultural Expo, Gosford Harmony Day, CC Mental Health Forum, Volunteer Expo at Erina, Wyong Interagency, Refugee Week Activity, Manager of Volunteers Forums, Community Partnership Forum, Stay Safe at the Beach, Connect Day at Niagara Park

We have continued to advertise: in the local media; The Senior newspaper; Community Newsletters; at Neighbourhood Centres, etc, by continuous distribution of service brochures, and by networking with other community services.



Multicultural Social Support Service

Anita Trainor

Funded by Department of Ageing, Disability & Home Care –
Home & Community Care (HACC) Program

This is a new project area funded in the 2009-2010 financial period. The purpose of this project is to provide opportunities for people born overseas (CALD) who are located in isolated areas of the Central Coast to interact socially, enjoy morning tea and lunch together, play games, listen to music or share information about their cultural backgrounds.

It was planned to have three groups which would meet once a week from three strategically located venues in order to facilitate the transport of consumers to the venues.

The three locations selected are: Peninsula Community Centre in Woy Woy, Blue Haven Community Centre and Mangrove Mountain Community Health Centre. Volunteers would assist with the transport of consumers to the above locations.

I was employed as the Coordinator for this project and commenced my employment on 6 April 2010, working three days per week. Immediately after commencing employment, I distributed promotional material in regards to the groups, contacted prospect referrers as well as the consumers in MSSS books in order to invite them to participate of this new initiative.

The groups commenced meeting at the beginning of May. The Blue Haven group meets on the Tuesdays; Woy Woy on the Thursdays and Wednesdays was left for the Mangrove Mountain group which did not start functioning at the same time as the others.

There have been difficulties in obtaining referrals for the Mangrove Mountain group due to the lack of referrals from the local community and local organisations and also in trying to break the cycle of the established routine in that particular geographical area.

The Blue Haven group's attendance has been irregular, mainly due to the competition from other organisations in the area, which offer social activities on the same day.



The Woy Woy group has had an exceptional success with new participants attending from week to week. There is a core of participants who have been attending from its beginning, they have formed very strong friendships and look forward to attending on a weekly basis. Currently the average number of attendees is between 9 and 10. Two volunteers have attended on a continuous basis since the start.



There is a good mix of nationalities in this group, such as: Greek, Spanish Speaking from various countries, German, Filipino, Portuguese, Maltese and South African. As the Mangrove Mountain group has not started yet, I have utilised that day for other activities, such as assessment of clients and volunteers, attending some community forums, participating in the organisation and development of monthly Client Days, attending team meetings at the office and attending activities at NSS Hamilton when required.

I have also attended NSS staff training with Shivani Gupta, one day training in First Aid Services, an information session in regards to the new Insurance Company for NSS. I also facilitated the same session for the volunteers, and any other activity which this office was organising.

The objects for this project in the next 12 months include:

- Plan for the recruitment of attendees for the group in Mangrove Mountain. This will require a local meeting with interested people in the community so that new ideas can be discussed.
- Continue with the intense recruitment of new attendees for the Blue Haven group as well as the prompt assessment of people willing to attend.
- Liaise with other organisations in the area, such as San Remo Neighbourhood Centre in order to develop a plan of cooperation between the two organisations.
- Continue to develop interesting activities, including picnics, for the summer months for the Woy Woy group and assess new referrals.

It has been a wonderful experience for me to work for NSS. I have had great pleasure in working with the CALD elderly, carers and people with a disability with the invaluable assistance from volunteers, for whom I have great respect.

I am looking forward to continue improving our services and work within a productive team.



Settlement Grants Program (Central Coast)

Danielle Habib

Funded by Department of Immigration & Citizenship

This project provides information, referral and support to highly disadvantaged, newly arrived migrants and refugees within their first five years of settlement, and also community development on the Central Coast.

Table 1: Client Work Major Issues

Case Work Issues	Contacts
Language	347
Employment	191
Volunteering	188
Education/ Training	157
Accommodation	150
Isolation	128
Family & Relationships/ Family Violence	119
Other	343
Total	1623

Casework Issues Identified

Table 1 shows the major casework issues, with one of these showing a dramatic increase, family violence. This has been experienced by migrants entering Australia on spouse visas mainly from China, Thailand and the Philippines. It has also impacted on the search for affordable accommodation and there is limited assistance from employment agencies in supporting clients into employment.

Community Capacity Building

The project has proven to be a leader in successful community capacity building through a number of events which have included:

- **“Stay Safe at the Beach”** In partnership with Centrelink, Gosford and Wyong Councils conducted the first “Stay Safe at the Beach” day in the Wyong Shire. The event supported activities and initiatives that foster a safe and healthy community; focusing on the migrant refugee community. It comprised of family activities to develop skills and knowledge of surf safety and awareness. Good coverage was given on local media and was nominated for a Community Builders Award.

African Education in Schools Program” In partnership with the Central Coast African Community, \$5000 was obtained to conduct African education in schools and addressed barriers of racism. Over 890 children in grades five and six, from five schools, learned about geography, religion, housing, culture and society. Drumming and percussion was also a highlight.

● **“Harmony Day”** Harmony Day received \$15,000 from Gosford Council. In partnership with 23 ethnic groups and the Aboriginal Community, the day showcased the varying cultures on the Central Coast and attracted 4500 people. This was the first time that the Aboriginal community had officially welcomed migrants to the Central Coast. The groups spent five months together, to prepare for the event. Harmony Day 2010 was nominated and won the Community Builders Award for ABCD Community Partnerships Event.

● **“Refugee Photographic Exhibition”**

A display of fifty refugee photos and stories was shown at Erina library and shopping centre. This had photos and stories of three refugees from the Central Coast who originated from Iraq, Sudan and Germany. The project also worked in partnership with Gosford City Council for it to become a “Refugee Friendly Zone”.



● **The Culturally and Linguistically Diverse Domestic Violence Steering Committee**

This is now into its second year and has strengthened partnerships with the Women's Health Centre, Centrelink and the Domestic Violence Court Support Advocacy Service. The Committee has been successful in receiving \$1500 in funding for a Domestic Violence Awareness and Support session for key CALD community members to support their communities.

Networking and Integration Services

The project continues to convene bimonthly the Central Coast Multicultural Interagency, a forum having regular attendance of 28 services. Interagency organised the Multicultural Expos held in September 2009 and 2010. The Expo had over 450 attendees with 40 varying service providers. Issues raised by interagency were: lack of use and knowledge of interpreters, increasing women and children suffering from family violence, need of an updated list of bi-lingual doctors and affordable housing.

The project networks in chairing the Central Coast Domestic Violence Committee and is a member of the Central Coast Community Women's Health Centre.

Danielle has also been fortunate in winning the Community Builders **Award** for best Individual Paid Employee, and says, “Thank you NSS for giving me the opportunity to work in the position that I truly love.”





Multicultural Family Support Project (Central Coast)

Pari Batha

Funded by Department of Community Services

This is a four day a week project and provides support to people from culturally and linguistically diverse (CALD) backgrounds who live on the Central Coast. In particular, women, families with young children and adolescents. The project also assists in providing information, advocacy, referrals, support and case work to government and non-government organisations and ethnic communities.

Table 1: Issues/Problems Presented by Clients: 2009-2010

Problem/issues	Face to Face	Telephone
Immigration	53	61
Income support	55	111
Education	93	109
Health (incl. Mental Health)	53	68
Housing	71	205
Legal	42	138
Employment	34	70
Domestic Violence	30	86
Ethnic Group work	84	367
Total	515	1215

Most clients are unaware of services and the support system on the Central Coast. Table 1 shows the main issues with which clients needed assistance. A Migrant Services Directory was also completed to support migrants and refugees on the Central Coast. A list of the many of the ethnic groups, ethnic contacts and different religious groups on the Central Coast is included and this also available on the Northern Settlement Services website. A hard copy is available for sale.

Community Development:

Consultation with the community and religious groups, included CALD students from Wyong TAFE, members of ethnic groups and diverse faith groups living on the Central Coast. The main issues raised were domestic violence, legal problems/issues, housing and rental problems and general feelings of isolation.

The project has the support of a Multicultural Support Group which has bimonthly meetings. The Mayor of Gosford and the Community Development Officer of Wyong Council have been guest speakers. Some issues were common to the members of the group such as locating venues to meet and public liability.

Events

The project participated in celebrations for Refugee Week, in partnership with the Green Point Community Centre. We had an insight into some refugee experiences thanks to a refugee from Tibet. The event was attended by over 100 people with many different members of the CALD community present.

Other events for the project included the Multicultural Expos for 2009 and 2010, which were very successful and the celebration of the Harmony Day at Gosford on 21 March 2010. The project also participated with the Wyong TAFE celebrations and Gosford Primary School where I spoke about Harmony Day. Community functions included the Indian New Year and Indian Independence Day celebrations organised by Ekta Mandir, Indian Group, the Chinese New Year and Chinese Moon Festivals, the Greek week and the Greek Art Exhibition and the Latino Day at Market Town Gosford.

Multicultural Movie Night (Film Global Night)

A monthly multicultural Movie Night on the Central Coast was a partnership between the project and Gosford Council Youth Services. It includes a cultural performance, specific foods and a film from the chosen cultural group. French, Iranian, Colombian, Indian, Greek, Maori, Italian, Filipino, Uruguayan and Chinese cultural groups have all participate. Between 50 and 150 people attend the movie night each month. The Central Coast Community Congress launched a DVD consisting Central Coast Community Stories. This DVD included a story about Film Global, one of three stories chosen.



Meetings and Networks

Meetings and networks attended by the project have been: the Central Coast Multicultural Interagency, the DoCS Hunter and Central Coast Advisory Committee, Multicultural Mental Health Advisory Committee, Central Coast Domestic Violence Court Advocacy Service, CALD Domestic Violence Steering Committee and Central Coast Cooperative Legal Service.



Training Provided

Cultural Awareness training was provided to 39 service providers, the Central Coast Voluntary service, Gosford Family Support Services, Life Line and for Multicultural Social Support Service volunteers.

Training attended

Training attended included: time for reflection conference, mental health, domestic and family violence, how to win grants, keeping them safe, family pathways day, and fostering children.

AGED SERVICES TEAM

Ms Sue (Slavica) Hristov
Aged Services Team Leader
Community Aged Care Packages Coordinator

Ms Lupe Fonua
Community Aged Care Packages Coordinator

Ms Tima 'Oto
Community Aged Care Packages Coordinator
Hunter Multicultural Respite Service Coordinator

Ms Enza Di Stefano
Community Visitors Scheme Coordinator

Ms Valerie Woodman
Multicultural Access Project – Hunter Coordinator



Community Aged Care Packages Sue Hristov, Lupe Fonua & Tima 'Oto Funded by Commonwealth Department of Health & Ageing

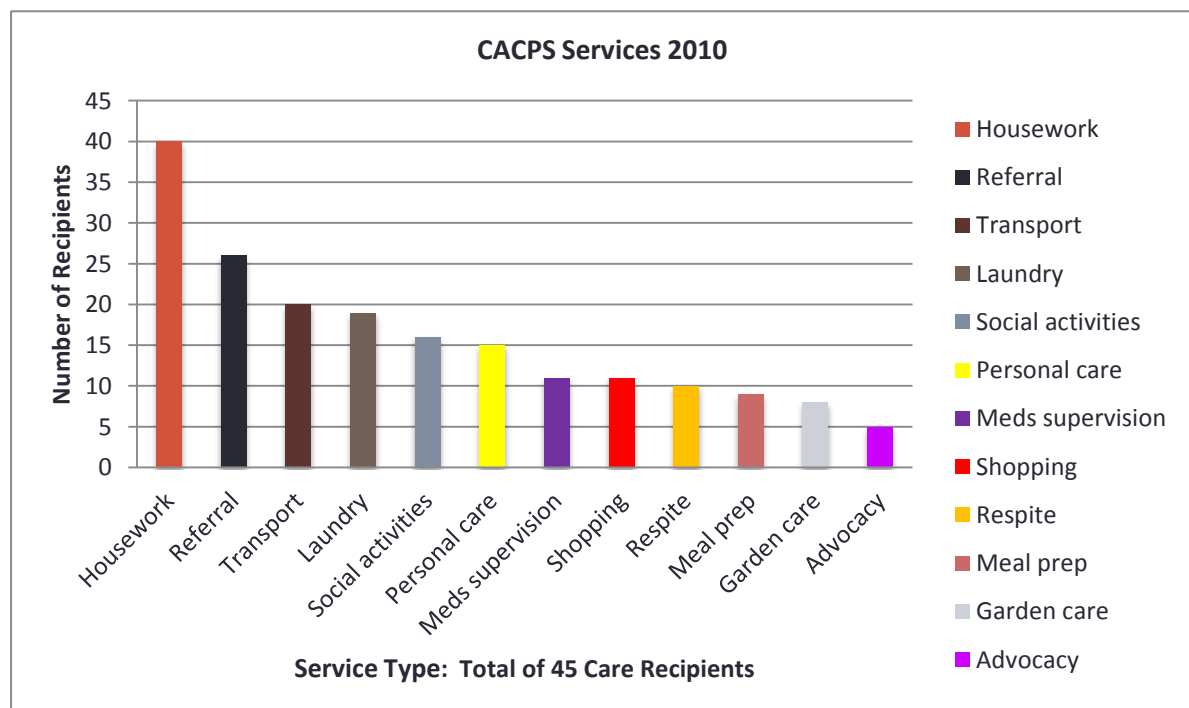
The Community Aged Care Project is in its 10th year of successful operation and continues to provide home based care and assistance to vulnerable, frail aged people who have complex care needs.

Our target group is older people from Culturally and Linguistically Diverse Backgrounds (CALD) in the Hunter region, who need assistance with the tasks of daily living to improve their quality of life and enable them to stay living at home as long as possible. We are currently funded to provide assistance to 42 people- however prudent financial management has enabled us to increase that number by an additional 3 people (unfunded) - and this number will increase even further in the coming year- we will be able to take on another couple of unfunded clients.

CARE RECIPIENT PROFILE

Our 45 care recipients come from 14 different cultural backgrounds: Italian(16); Greek (5); Polish (4); Macedonian (4); German (3); Hungarian; (2); Slovenian (2); Sri Lankan (2); Chinese (2); Vietnamese (1); Guyana (1); Japanese (1); Ukrainian(1); Russian (1). Total of 45 care recipients:

- 30 Female -15 Male- age range from 71 to 93 years old
- 26 living at home alone - 19 have a carer living with them
- 2 double packages- care provided to both husband and wife
- 11 having a diagnosis of dementia



LEVEL OF SERVICE PROVISION

We currently provide 152 hrs direct assistance (140 hrs last year) per week - an average of 4 hrs (up from 3 hrs last year) per care recipient – some require only 1-2 hrs per week and others with complex care needs and/or those who do not have live in carers or other family/ support networks require significantly more- one as high as 16hrs per week. The past year has seen a very small drop in the number of people (18% as compared to 19% last year) who required a higher level of care than a CACP is generally designed to provide- about 5.5hrs/wk.

MODEL OF SERVICE PROVISION

The overall responsibility for Program management/ Service Coordination falls to the 3 Coordinators while direct service provision (care workers who go to people's homes) is contracted from 7 reputable agencies- this model continues to serve our organisation well as it allows us to meet people's needs in a culturally appropriate way. Another often challenging, but rewarding, element of the Program is the case management/ ongoing monitoring of complex care needs of care recipients. Coordinators are available on a 24hr/7days/wk On-call arrangement - something that is very much appreciated by care recipients/ families.

QUALITY REPORTING PROCESS

Our participation in the CACP 3 yearly Quality Reporting requirement, though nerve racking, proved to be a very positive and professionally affirming experience. At the site visit the assessors stated that they saw ample evidence that we have a commitment to a culture of continuous improvement: and

- That service recipients and other stakeholders are involved in checking and improving service quality and that information gathered is incorporated into relevant improvement planning processes
- Demonstrated appropriate results for each of the Community Care Standards
- That NSS demonstrated outcomes to support and assist frail older people to continue to live in, and connect, to their community/

NSS CACP was seen as “providing a best practice model of how the brokerage model of service provision, can best meet the culturally and linguistically diverse needs of people from CALD backgrounds to the high standard required.”

The 2009 Annual Client Satisfaction Survey confirmed a very high level of client/ carer/family satisfaction with all aspects of our service delivery: both with the assistance provided in the home by carer workers as well as the coordination/case management- eg: “Most like the caring and supportive workers- well liked/ respected by both my parents/family members” ; “My needs are listened to” - “Ease of communication at all levels- friendliness and prompt response to my needs” – “Privacy is respected” – “Job getting done with care” - “Coordinator very helpful and will go out of her way to do whatever she can to assist” - “Coordinator is a very caring person and mum is fortunate to have someone like her looking after her”.

The past year has been a busy but rewarding one for the CACP Project – all made immeasurably easier through the continuing support from the Board of Management, Violetta and fellow colleagues/service providers.



Hunter Multicultural Respite Service

Tima 'Oto

Funded by Department of Ageing, Disability & Homecare
- Home & Community Care Program (HACC)

Hunter Multicultural Respite Service (HMRS) provides respite care for frail older people or people with dementia from non-English speaking backgrounds experiencing difficulty in attending Day Care Centres. The service provides a culturally appropriate worker to assist with care of clients at Day Care Centres to sustain their placement at Day Care and to provide their carers some respite.

Model of Service Provision

HMRS is staffed by one part-time coordinator (3 days per week) and direct care services are provided on a brokerage model, i.e. care workers are contracted as needed from other existing providers such as Uniting Care, Home Care and Extra Care and Novacare. The brokerage model has proven to be an efficient and effective model, as it enables the project to have a wider pool of workers to choose from and enables the service to better meet the cultural and linguistic needs of particular clients.

Services provided

Throughout 2010 a total of 24 clients have received weekly services of between 2-8 hours per week, including transport for 2 clients. 7 clients attend 2-3 days per week. A total of 7 new clients have commenced services since the beginning of this year and 7 clients ceased service mainly due to placement into permanent residential care and or becoming too frail to attend. All clients have been formally assessed initially and reviewed after 6 months of service. There are no clients on the waiting list and every client referred has been offered service.

In 2010 the Project has:

- Provided 2448 hours of service- about 8.5 hours per client per month
- contracted 20 care workers for direct service provision



Table 1: Day Care Centres & Clients

Day Care Centre	No of clients per Day Care Centres at 30/10/2010
Allawah Day Centre, Wallsend	1
Cardiff Multicultural Friendship Group	1
East Lake Macquarie Dementia service	1
Greek Day Care	3
Greek Holy Apostles Day Care	3
Italian Day Care	7
Macedonian Day Care	1
Maitland Multicultural Friendship Group	2
Polish Day Care	6
Southlakes Day Care, Morisset	1
TOTAL	26 clients

Multicultural Dementia Support Group- support for carers

This year's calendar was changed from Tuesday to Wednesday to accommodate members who were not able to attend on Tuesday - this will be reviewed for next year's meetings. The service coordinates the monthly meeting of the group (jointly with Community Options) on the third Wednesday of the month. Throughout the year we have had speakers and information sessions to assist and support carers. The highlight of this year's calendar was a trip to Sydney to the taping of Channel 10 "Ready Steady Cook". The Community Visitor's Scheme's volunteers joined our group on this occasion. There were 2 shows taped on the day we attended and one was aired in early July and we are still waiting for the second taping to be aired. This was to coincide with the Volunteers Week Celebration.

For the Carers Week in October we arranged for a cruise on Lake Macquarie and Community Visitors Scheme Volunteers joined us. It was a lovely day on the Lake and everyone enjoyed the outing.

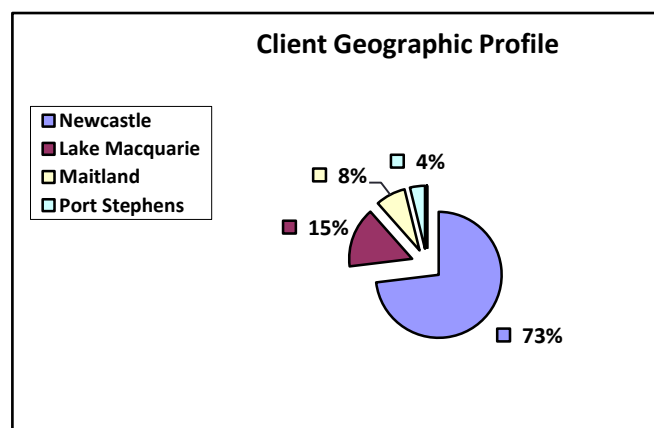
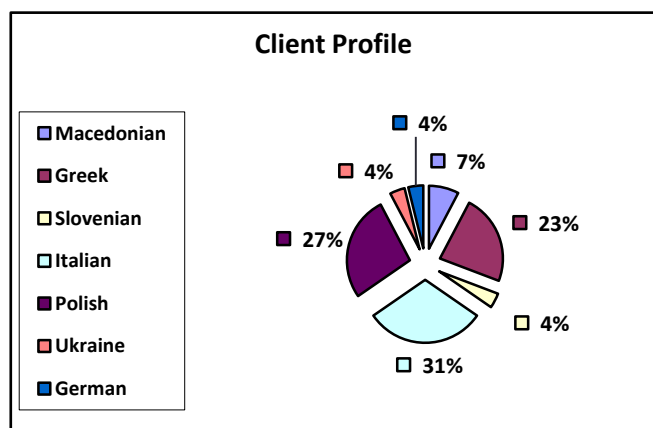
We also organised a bus trip to explore the Macadamia Farm at Medowie (pictured right).

A Volunteer Register was started to include carers who wish to continue supporting the group when they no longer have someone to care for at home or nursing home. Three volunteers have already registered.



Table 2: Client Characteristics

Gender		Age			Client condition		
Male	Female	55-69	70-79	80-89	90+	Dementia	Frail Aged
5	21	2	5	16	3	14	12



Administration

- An ADHC grant of \$2738 is being used for training and recruitment of volunteers and further operational assistance to carers and their families.
- New agreements and risk assessments of Day care Centres were signed off throughout the year to follow up from DADHC Review/ Action plan
- MDS database was updated to the new HADS format and data successfully transferred / statistics compiled and sent to DADHC quarterly.

Training / conferences attended throughout the year include:

- Completed Cert IV in Service Coordination (Ageing and Disability) with Pragmatic Training Co
- Completed Cert IV in Community Services (Service Coordination) with Pragmatic Training Co
- Completed Certificate in Ill in Aged Care - Provide Support to people living with Dementia (over a period of 6 weeks)

Meetings attended on a regular basis include:

- Quality and Team meetings, Aged Care Team Monthly Meeting
- HACC services and Community Services Network quarterly meetings
- Dementia Interagency meetings & Upper Hunter Interagency

I would like to thank the Board and my colleagues at NSS for their assistance and support, which has enabled the service to consolidate and build successfully throughout 2010.



Community Visitors Scheme

Enza Di Stefano

Funded by Commonwealth Department of Health & Ageing

Introduction

The NSS Community Visitors Scheme (CVS) provides socially isolated residents of aged care facilities in the Lower Hunter, who are from Culturally/Linguistically Diverse Backgrounds (CALD), a better quality of life through one on one volunteer visits. Over the past 12 months 20 Facilities have been visited- a total of 905 visits to 41 residents - 18,138 kilometres travelled.

Community Visitor Recruitment and Turnover:

Recruitment of NSS CVS visitors is an on-going process and during the year 21 visitors were available. This CVS program is very fortunate to have longstanding volunteers with a great gender balance, currently there are 13 women and 8 men. During the year 4 new visitors have been recruited. As can be seen from the Activity Report, 7 visitors visit more than one facility -due to the need of a specific language/cultural background; and 6 visitors visit more than one resident (separately – on a one to one basis) at the same facility- again due to the need of a specific language/cultural background and or the presence of dementia. One visitor resigned due to changed family commitments, the visited resident was able to be matched with a current volunteer. On a sadder note one of our dear visitors passed away suddenly in April – he was a very youthful 82 and his cheery disposition will be missed by all.

Orientation Activities:

Individual orientation for prospective visitors including Police Checks has been conducted on a needs basis, throughout the year. The three yearly renewal of police checks has been undertaken for 11 visitors. All visitors are regularly contacted (at least once a month) either through a phone call, email or mail to maintain communication and support. A Parkinson Disease Information Package was researched and collated by the co-ordinator for the visitor of a new resident suffering the disease. A visitor underwent major surgery in April, support and visiting by the co-ordinator was undertaken; the volunteer re-commenced visiting in June.

Promotional Activities:

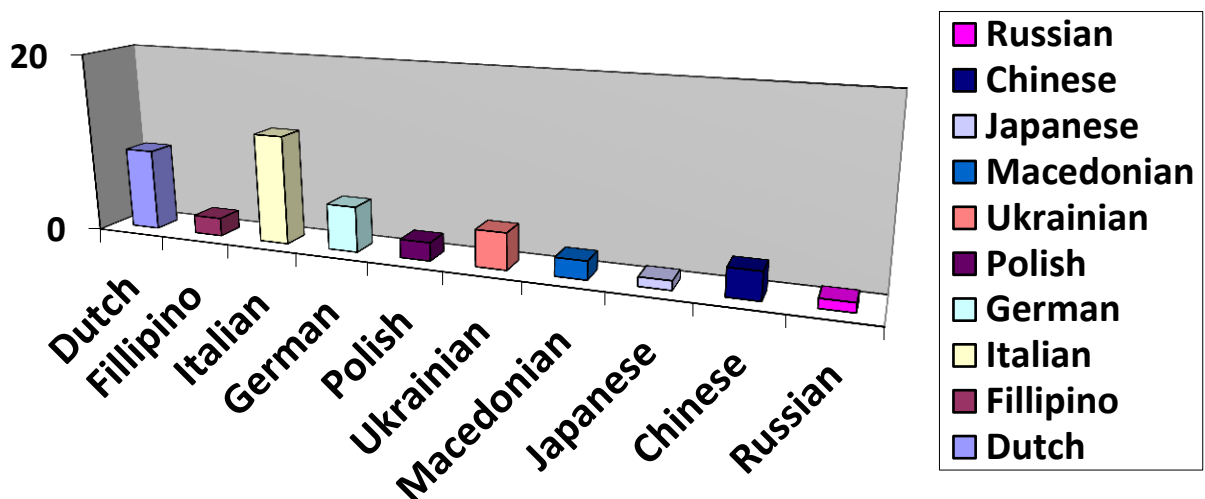
The most successful promotion activities have proven to be the extensive and longstanding contacts and good working relationships with local ethnic communities/organisations and networks servicing a similar target group. Regular visits to the various community groups maintains the profile and accessibility of the CVS program at a grass roots level.

Networking:

Networking with other CVS auspices in the region continues with two referrals – one Macedonian and one Russian speaking visitors being referred to NSS CVS program. Participated in 2 regional CVS Network Meetings and the NSW CVS State Forum – these meetings allow workers the opportunity to discuss issues of concern namely the “active visitor” definition, new CVS Guidelines, promotion of the CVS Program and alternate ways of recruiting volunteers. A request for assistance in purchasing appropriate resources from an Aged Care Facility. After liaising with the facilities Lifestyle Co-ordinator the CVS co-ordinator on behalf of the facility purchased three CDs and four DVDs in the nominated language.

Visits to the Lifestyle Co-ordinators of two new Aged Care Facilities promoting the unique NSS CVS Program in the Hunter has proved beneficial with five successfully placed new referrals.

The 41 Residents' Cultural Background



Special events acknowledging the invaluable contribution of visitors:

“Dancing With Our Stars” was held during Carer’s Week Celebrations in October 2009, and the ‘Christmas Thankyou Lunch’ was held in December. During Volunteer Week in May 2010 a bus trip was organised to Chanel 10 studios in Sydney for the taping of READY STEADY COOK. This was a very successful day with the volunteers enjoying the experience of being behind the scenes of making and watching the taping of the television cooking program. Everyone was thrilled when the host of the show acknowledged the presence of the Newcastle and Hunter NSS CVS program and volunteers in the audience live to air – an unexpected valuable acknowledgement and promotion of the program.

Benefits of the Scheme:

The principle benefit of the Scheme is that Visitors play an integral role in easing the social and cultural isolation experienced by many residents who may not have family living close by and whose extended support networks were left behind when they migrated. Having a Visitor from a similar cultural background also provides an opportunity for residents to maintain a link to the community through sharing of news and current activities in the community.

A Cultural Exchange took place at the Kressville Lodge Hostel in Cooranbong with one of the CVS wonderful volunteers presenting a display and talk on Holland. This was very well received by all the residents and staff who attended – some 24 people. Subsequent to the presentation, the Dutch resident has been befriended by other residents who now have a better understanding and appreciation of his heritage. The resident stated that he feels that a barrier has been lifted and feels much more open and at ease.

Identified Difficulties:

The main difficulty remains the recruitment of suitable visitors from the diminishing ethnic population group who are an ageing population. This diminishing pool has necessitated adopting a useful and necessary strategy of a number of visitors seeing more than one resident in the same facility and often in different facilities. This strategy has resulted in the program being able to provide support to a larger number of residents who would otherwise miss out.

Satisfaction with the Service Provided:

The feedback through both our networks and our direct relationship with the various aged care facilities indicates that the service provided is most appreciated and valued. In most Hunter Region Aged Care Facilities there are few second language speakers among staff; this means that even with the best intentions staff are unable to communicate with most of the NESB background residents. The NSS CVS is able to support communication within the facility environment through the use of their language skills and the friendships they establish.





Multicultural Access Project - Hunter

Valerie Woodman

Funded by Ageing, Disability and Home Care

-NSW Department of Human Services

-Home and Community Care Program (HACC)

The service provides strategic advice, information, referral and assistance to multicultural, ethno specific and mainstream services to improve outcomes for frail aged and younger people with a disability and carers from a culturally and linguistically diverse (CALD) background.

A key role is to research and report on the needs of the frail aged, younger people with a disability and carers from a CALD background in the Hunter to inform the HACC (Home and Community Care) planning process so that services are culturally appropriate and responsive to specific needs.

The project also provides information to CALD communities to increase their awareness of and access to a range of community support services.

The major focus during 2009-10 has been to promote the project and establish a professional relationship with relevant ADHC (Ageing, Disability and Home Care) Departmental officers, HACC and similar community support service providers in the Hunter. This has been achieved by actively participating in the Hunter CALD Advisory Group, Muswellbrook Seniors Expo, attending interagency and network meetings across the Hunter and providing regular project updates to members.

A MAP Advisory Committee has been established meeting in February, April and June. The meetings are proving to be an effective forum to identify and discuss current and emerging issues effecting both the HACC service sector and CALD communities.



A key action of the MAP Service Plan 2009-10 was to establish and maintain a CALD service provider network. A survey was conducted to gauge the level of interest in a professional network which was followed up with a forum on 26 May 2010 to discuss the relevance, benefit and scope of such a network. Based on feedback at this forum the Hunter CALD Aged and Disability Services Network has been set up; Terms of Reference endorsed and members will meet three times each year at various locations with each meeting to have a specific focus/topic.

A second key action is to explore issues surrounding the recruitment of bilingual workers in the HACC sector. The strategy to elicit this information across the ADHC Hunter Planning Region which includes the Central Coast was to work in partnership with the Central Coast MAP worker to develop and distribute an online survey to 75 Hunter/Central Coast HACC services. It is gratifying to report an 82 per cent response rate from these HACC services.



Responses have been collated and a report on findings drafted which will be incorporated into a final report once a second survey targeting individual bilingual workers and volunteers is analysed and collated. This research will guide the development of recommendations and strategies to increase the HACC bilingual staffing pool to enhance equitable access to culturally appropriate support services.

Advocacy on regional matters and service gaps is ongoing - for example transport to day centres, access to interpreter services and issues regarding older CALD peoples' inability to access the HACC Community Care Access Point were raised at the HACC Triennial Planning CALD specific consultation on 9 June 2010.

The project has actively participated in the NSW Regional MAP Network and hosted the June 2010 meeting with members travelling from the Blue Mountains, Sydney and the Central Coast to attend.

A literature search on dementia specific research was conducted with no results found on current research or data on the incidence, knowledge and beliefs of CALD communities in the Hunter on dementia. A proposal and business case has been developed to undertake this research and forwarded to ADHC for consideration. Findings from such research would provide a practical tool for service development, capacity and competency to meet the needs of CALD clients with dementia and their carers now and in the future.

In April 2010 the federal government announced it would be taking full responsibility (funding, policy and delivery) for aged care services from 1 July 2012 under the new National Health and Hospitals Network Agreement. This includes home and community care provided to older Australians. The federal government has stated that there will be no significant changes to current funding arrangements until 2015. It is unclear what impact this will have on non-direct services such as MAPs however the value and effectiveness of these regional based projects has been articulated in a submission to the Productivity Commission's Inquiry into Caring for Older Australians by the NSW Ethnic Communities Council.

I have thoroughly enjoyed my first year working with NSS and wish to sincerely thank the Board and staff for welcoming me into the 'fold', for sharing their knowledge and skills so generously and for making me feel valued as a colleague.

REFUGEE SUPPORT TEAM

Ms Kiri Hata
Complex Case Support Coordinator
African Team Leader

Ms Flora Aine *(til July 2010)*
African Communities Worker

Mr Tonkoh Kamara
African Youth Worker

Ms Zenaida Edmunds
Parenting Support Project Worker

Ms Helen Buchanan
Life Skills & Parenting Groups Project Worker

Ms Joselyne Ntahomvukiye
African Family Welfare Worker

Ms Amer Manyon
African Parenting Assistant

Alhousseynou Ly & Ms Robyn Graham
African Family Support Workers (Mauritanian)

Mr Michael Freund
Volunteers Coordinator (Educational Programs)

Ms Olivia Graham *(til Feb 2010)* / **Ms Georgina Ramsay**
Volunteers Coordinator (Welfare Programs)



Refugee Support Team Leader
Kiri Hata

Overview:

The Refugee Support Team was in previous years known as the African Team. The name was changed in recognition of the fact that our services and support are offered to all arrivals that come to the region as refugees. It also reflects the shifting priority areas and perceived future needs for refugee relocation as identified by the Australian government.

The team is comprised of 10 staff providing a wide range of settlement services to refugees in the Newcastle region in the 2009 – 10 financial year. With funding from a range of sources, we have supported highly disadvantaged recently arrived refugees from various African countries (Sudan, Burundi, Congo, Liberia, Mauritania, Rwanda, Sierra Leone, Uganda, Somalia, Ethiopia and Ivory Coast) as well as Iraq, Iran and Afghanistan. The range of issues faced by these individuals and families included accommodation, family relationships, education and employment, referrals to help with family reunion, legal and financial matters and general welfare support.

The path to our front door has been much used, and somewhat widened, by those seeking our help during the year. More than 6,000 face-to-face meetings were held with clients and appropriate information and referrals made. Staff provided over 7,500 instances of telephone advice and either arranged and delivered – or took an active role in – more than 400 training / information sessions. Additionally, there were 17 presentations / cross-cultural trainings to mainstream services, 9 sessions with University and TAFE students preparing to work in Social Welfare and/or as community workers; and representation at many inter-agency meetings and gatherings in the Newcastle, Maitland and Lake Macquarie areas.

Building and maintaining key partnerships has again proven worthwhile in providing positive outcomes for our clients, particularly in times of great upset and stress. We are a major point of referral for mainstream services, assisting them to improve their response to client needs. We also walk the path of access and information and referral with our clients to ensure they receive the same services to which all Australian residents are entitled.

While there were few new arrivals to the region during this year, there were mainly relocations and family reunions experienced by the earlier arriving refugees. The Congolese arrivals at the end of the last financial year were progressively moved into the SGP program during the period and kept the team busy with housing and welfare support matters. Many of these arrivals were large families and required extensive support on matters of parenting, education and legal obligations.

An important innovation of the year has been the instigation of a community consultation process with the African community to gather their feedback and wishes around the support offered by NSS. The first meeting held on June 27 saw the NSS meeting room packed to capacity with many of the communities represented. The purpose of the gathering was to receive individual issues and key information and feedback that could provide direction to our services for the coming year. This consultation is to be the first of a regular program, with the next to be with invited community representatives and leaders (twice a year) and an annual community gathering to encourage communities and individuals to provide input to our service delivery.

One of the most time-consuming issues for the team is the ongoing need for affordable housing for clients. We have relocated more than 30 families and individuals during this period and negotiated additional Housing NSW support for those who were most disadvantaged. We have been greatly assisted in this by Maureen Mitchell and the other volunteers at Penola House, Sisters Betty Brown and Diana Santleben, and volunteers who search the internet every week for rental houses.

Funding:

Funding for the programs under the Refugee Support Team banner came from the Department of Immigration and Citizenship (DIAC) – Settlement Grants Program; Department of Families and Housing, Community Services and Indigenous Affairs (FAHCSIA) – Stronger Family and Community Strategy; Department of Community Services (DOCS – now known as Department of Human Services, Community Services); NSW Clubs (CDSE) and NSS core funding.

Staff:

The year saw some small staff movements, but the core team remained in place and committed to the needs of the community we serve.

- **Flora Aine** (full time worker) provided great service as the SGP African Support Worker on a very wide range of issues. She also built and maintained outreach support into the African and Arabic-speaking community through TAFE in Maitland, and assisted all of the African women's groups to develop dance and cultural groups who found success in attracting local funding for their performances;
- **Helen Buchanan**, in two days per week, found new and exciting ways of engaging the community in parenting programs and training opportunities, in partnership with Penola House, TAFE, NSW Health and a range of other services. These led to the very successful and highly visible African Training Markets held bi-monthly in Hamilton;
- **Amer Manyon** maintained her 7 hours per week African Parenting Assistant community role through Penola House, acting to engage and involve the Sudanese, Burundian and Mauritanian women in sewing classes and other programs;

- **Joselyne Ntahomvukiye**, the African Family support worker utilised her 1 day per week role to actively engage the Central African communities in all programs at Penola House, as well as providing casework and referral services to a steadily growing community. She was also central to guiding and training the younger women to success in winning the inaugural Newcastle PCYC Talent Quest with their dancing;
- **Alhousseynou Ly** and **Robyn Graham** provided 2 days per week support to the Mauritanian community over 8 months of the year. This community found strength in working together on both settlement issues and maintenance of their language and culture and have developed a thriving community language school which attracts resources and support from a range of NSW and Federal services;
- **Tonkoh (Mohamed) Kamara** (full time worker) strengthened the role of African Youth Worker by building links with schools with African students, and delivering a regular visit and mentoring programs with students. He built strong networks with mainstream services and actively engaged the African Youth in many programs, including the Newcastle Talent Quest and a wide variety of sporting opportunities;
- **Zeni Edmunds** was a very welcome addition when she transferred into the team as a 2 day per week Parenting Support worker, providing programs for Mothers and Babies, giving a focus to the role of parents as first teachers and how to stimulate growth and development of children in Australia, in preparation for their formal education years;
- **Michael Freund**, Coordinator of Volunteers was so successful in his role that NSS was able to attract additional funding to provide homework centres at 3 new schools. He works 4.5 days per week and was joined in 2010 by **Olivia Graham** for 2 months, then **Georgina Ramsay** since March, 2010. Georgina works as Volunteers Coordinator – Welfare, two days per week, and Michael is the Volunteers Coordinator – Education, still on 4.5 days per week; and finally,
- Myself (**Kiri Hata**) as team leader, I provide leadership and casework support and direction to the whole team; review needs and allocate drop-in clients; support client housing needs; and work with specific communities to achieve identified outcomes.

From July 1, 2010 our team welcomed **Stephen Mawa Luka** and **Nellie Srisurapon**, who have taken over Flora Aine's role while she is on maternity leave. Flora had a baby boy on July 13, 2010.



Conclusion:

It has been my pleasure to provide support and leadership to this team of committed and capable co-workers. I recognise that we continue to build on the success and strength of those who went before us, and I trust that we will continue to meet the needs of all refugee arrivals to the Hunter and Newcastle regions.



Refugee Welfare, African Communities Project

Flora Aine

Funded by Department of Immigration & Citizenship

This project provided information, referral and casework support services to disadvantaged African refugees and migrants in the Newcastle, Maitland and Lake Macquarie regions. It is funded by the Department of Immigration and Citizenship (DIAC) under the Settlement Grants Program.

Casework and referrals

During the period, the project helped 631 clients through one-to-one casework and appropriate referrals. More than 2,700 referrals (both formal and informal) were also made to other services and government agencies, depending on the need.

Housing, health, education and legal issues were the dominant needs, with most clients also requiring language support.

Regular outreach to Maitland TAFE saw the growth of a group and subsequent support network among African women and other Arabic speakers from different regions.

The majority of clients continue to come from the Sudanese community, which also reflects the size of the community in relation to other African groups and the longer time they have lived in this region.

Training and Group Sessions:

The program organised and ran 112 sessions to the client group, aiming to help them become self-reliant. While many of the sessions were generally grouped around parenting knowledge and skills in Australia, two programs stood out for participants. The legal issues and the legal system series was well received, with clients meeting with police and solicitors, visiting court, understanding domestic violence and the penalties under Australian law. This program was run for three different African groups and had consistently high attendance.

Another successful program was the Pharmacy Training, in which clients were taught about services, medications and advice available from Pharmacists. Groups were given advice on the range of products available over the counter and the circumstances when it was important to go straight to a doctor or the hospital. Many of the clients did not know that a key role of a pharmacist was to provide advice and information, particularly when a person does not know whether a matter required further medical intervention.

Social Integration:

Together with a core team of African volunteers, the project was able to involve many of the African community in the planning and delivery of the Jesmond Multicultural Community Festival in October 2009 (pictured below). Not only did the communities provide much of the entertainment with dancers from the various regions, they were also able to generate income from a BBQ stall run by the Burundi men. Their keenest customers were the students of Callaghan College and the NSW Police. Some of the profits went to the women's performance groups to help pay for their dance uniforms.

The Equatorian Women, Burundian Women and Sudanese Women each formed their own dance and cultural groups during the year and held regular meetings to elect leaders and open bank accounts for any money raised. These groups were very active in responding to requests to showcase their skills at local government gatherings, service agencies, training and education conferences and programs, and entertained at over 14 different events – all of which paid for their input.

At least 5 community members were photographed and interviewed for the Refugee Day Photographic Exhibition which was shown around NSW.

I presented 10 sessions through the year with a focus on cultural issues and concerns around matters of health (for doctors and medical staff), legal issues (lawyers and police), family relationships (counselling and support agencies), education (teachers) and welfare (University and TAFE students).

Networks and Meetings:

As a result of the networks attended and the casework support provided, I was able to play a role in a policy shift in the procedures of NSW Health in ensuring only female interpreters are used with clients on issues of women's health.

I attended NSS case worker meetings, the Multicultural Refugee Interagency, the Newcastle Forum, Maitland Neighbourhood Centre, Jesmond Neighbourhood Centre, TAFE, Lake Macquarie Interagency and meetings of other services on request.

Conclusion:

I am very happy to have been a member of the Refugee Support Team and enjoyed working with everyone to achieve the objectives of our program.





African Youth Project

Tonkoh Kamara

Funded by Department of Immigration & Citizenship

The aim of the project is to identify and address the issues of young people from migrant and humanitarian background aged from 12-24 years living in Newcastle with outreach to Lake Macquarie and Maitland. The position aims to increase youth participation in accessing existing services and to develop responses to cover gaps in youth services provision, especially to small and emerging communities.

The main work of the project is to provide support, information, referral, casework, advocacy, mentoring, service planning and development and capacity building to assist young people from humanitarian and migrant background in their settlement. The project also participates in local and regional youth and community networks.

Recreational Activities

I have developed and supported a range of sporting and recreational activities for young migrants and humanitarian entrant during 2009-2010, which have been a great way of encouraging young people to participate in community activities, assisting with their integration into Australian life, improving self-confidence and developing life skills. These include:

- Weekly activities at Newcastle Police & Citizen's Youth Club (PCYC);
- Weekly basketball games for African Lions team.
- Weekly social activities at Hamilton South Community Centre (run by Samaritans Foundation);
- Migrant youth soccer teams (Flying Eagles and The Lions) in friendly matches against mainstream teams at the TAFE grounds;
- Several camping excursions in partnership with STARTTS;
- Weekly Youth dance group practise at NSS;
- Newcastle Talent Quest run in partnership with PCYC and the West African Youth;
- School holiday activity at the TAFE soccer ground in partnership with STARTTS and Jobquest; and
- Youth mentoring program at San Clemente Catholic High School in partnership with STARTTS.

Education & Training:

Large numbers of young Africans are enrolled in various primary and high schools and TAFE around Newcastle and Hunter Region, and since its inception the project has been working with schools and parents for the purpose of integrating newly arrived young people into the mainstream community. I have attended regular meetings in schools with staff and parents, and run sessions on cultural awareness and educational pathways.

The project has worked with the following schools; St. Francis Xavier in Hamilton, Lambton High, San Clemente High (Mayfield) and Waratah Technology Campus. Our aim is to mentor and build confidence and self esteem in students, and to break down communication barriers between these students, their parents and school staff. I provided information sessions to other agencies and services such as Centrelink, DET, Health and Community Services. I also set up opportunities for migrant students to meet with Police to discuss their concerns.

Skill Development:

I am finishing my Bachelor of Social Science degree at the University of Newcastle this year. I attended the DIAC Development Conference in April 2010, which provided training for SGP workers in regional and rural NSW.

Outreach:

During the period I met with more than 600 young people seeking support to access services or resolve issues. I also provided over 900 telephone advices, information and referrals. The majority of young people who sought our service came from Sudan (53%) – an increase in numbers due to our success in promotion as well as the relocation of others who were discouraging young people from accessing the services to which they were entitled. The other main youth communities seeking assistance were Liberian, Burundian, Congolese and Mauritanian.

The good relationship this project has with schools and community services provides relatively easy access to the client group.

Conclusion:

This project has been able to support young African refugees and other migrants in a range of activities, as well as focus on and support other agencies in the direct need of migrant and humanitarian young people. It has also assisted with the development of strategies to support youths and to encourage their self esteem and independence.





Parenting Support Project

Zenaida Edmunds

Funded by Department of Families & Housing, Community Services & Indigenous Affairs

The Northern Settlement Services Parenting Support Project provides parenting support to teenage mothers and first time mothers from refugee, humanitarian entrants and culturally linguistically (CALD) background families, who are identified as disadvantaged, isolated, vulnerable and families at risk. These families are experiencing hardships, effects of torture and trauma, physical and psychological crisis encountered in their settlement.

Parenting support includes; individual support, referrals, weekly group activities and information sessions and the project is funded for 14 hours a week.

The number of families accessing the service during the 12 month period totals 14 from Liberian, Burundi, Sudanese, Congolese, Sierra Leone, Japanese, Thai, Chinese, Italian backgrounds.

Activities:

Mothers and Babies Group –operating every Tuesday and Thursday morning

Group Work:

The project has established and operated a “Mothers and Baby’s Group”, activities include weekly sessions and information sessions. Activities provided during the sessions enhance child’s physical development, social development and emotional development. It also provides modelling for positive interaction between mothers and babies in informal and informative environment.

Table1. Issues Presented:

Issues	Face to Face	Telephone
Transport	19	11
English language	12	12
Childcare	15	11
Immunisation	15	10
Child's Nutrition/Allergies	15	14
Family and Relationships	13	11
Baby's Sleeping Pattern	16	15
Teething	14	12
Accessing Medical services	15	10
Breastfeeding/Bottle feeding	14	10
Housing/Accommodation	16	12
Financial Management	15	11
Child Development	16	14
Total	195	153

Activities/Topics Include:

- Tummy Time – Muscle Development
- Hearing and Speech
- Nutrition and Allergies
- Vestibular Stimulation
- Rhythm and Music - Movement
- Baby Massage
- Hand Development/Feet Culture
- Body Awareness/Muscle Tone
- Behaviour

**Project's Outcome:**

Approximately 85% of mothers attending the sessions have knowledge of;

- Providing their babies with appropriate and suitable activities
- Providing a more positive interaction with their babies
- Accessing mainstream support services independently

Issues to address:

- Unavailability of suitable transport limits the participation of mothers in attending information sessions and the weekly group sessions.
- The loss of extended family in target communities contributes to difficulties new mothers are experiencing with their babies.
- Lack of English language proficiency limits mothers understanding of some of the alternative and positive strategies of parenting. It also a contributing factor of isolation.
- Lack of understanding of Australian custom and culture also contributes to isolation.

I would like to thank my colleagues for their ongoing support and encouragement, to Violetta, for her trust and the NSS Board, for their dedication to the worthy cause that we all do.



Life Skills & Parenting Groups

Helen Buchanan

Funded by Department of Immigration & Citizenship
- Settlement Grants Program (SGP) &
Department of Families & Housing, Community Services &
Indigenous Affairs

The African Parenting Groups and Life Skills Program were set up with funding under the Department of Immigration and Citizenship (DIAC) Settlement Grants Program and the Department of Families and Housing, Community Services and Indigenous Affairs (FAHCSIA) – Stronger Family and Community Strategy.

These programs were designed to improve the parenting skills of African parents, encourage independent living skills and build the capacity for problem solving and engaging with mainstream services for some of the most disadvantaged in our community. The purpose is to develop new skills and address the cross cultural issues which stop refugees from thriving in their new home.

The major issues faced by many in these groups include housing and tenancy issues, negotiating better access to services and benefits, legal and court support, nutrition and health information, education and employment opportunities.

There were 14 different groups run at Penola House over the year, mostly based around specific community groups and some gender specific. Several of the groups were able to develop skills and capacities that began to generate income. These included the BBQ groups, Training markets and the handyman program. Media coverage of some of the groups also resulted in community and organisational support with donations and goods for use by participants.

African Refugee Training Markets:

The African Refugee Training markets were developed in response to the lack of access to culturally specific foods and goods and the interest and overseas experience of many Africans in selling goods to gain income.



In order to prepare and sell goods in Australian markets, all participants have had to be trained to Australian standards in personal and food hygiene. We have achieved this through group work in partnership with TAFE. With the focus on group development, rather than individual business development, we have run regular, well attended sessions on matters as diverse as OH&S, insurance, preparation and presentation of food for public sale and consumption, food allergies and health issues. Council licensing, resource management and the language required, have taken the groups to new levels of understanding which can only benefit them in their daily lives.

The skills learnt in preparation for the markets have also seen a shift in the way communities come together to celebrate and many families now join together for group BBQ and picnics. **(Photo Right: Children African Drumming)**



The groups have also received invitations to provide performances and cook at a variety of cultural festivals including the University of NSW, various school and church events. This has been a great platform for learning and developing more business like skills alongside their parenting skills.

Additionally, we now have 9 trained Baristas among the groups, all vying to provide the best coffee to customers! The fund raising programs of each group have given us the opportunity to run leadership training, improve money handling and secretarial skills and develop business planning models that will give benchmarks against which to assess success.

The bi-monthly markets are held in Hamilton at the James Street Plaza and have proven to be a regular photo opportunity for local TV and print media and were presented in a recent DIAC newsletter as an example of best practice.

Parenting Programs:

Many of the parenting programs have run with the input of the specific Refugee Support Team members working with individual communities. The first half of the period saw many participants engaging in all opportunities offered, but this dropped off at the beginning of 2010 due to the periodic attendance requirements of Centrelink for TAFE students. This began to change with the advent of the new financial year in July, 2010.

Health, nutrition and social / relaxation skills attracted additional participants, as did the walking for health program for mothers and children.

Art Exhibition:

A successful Art Exhibition was held during the year, with artworks by refugee clients, both young and old. Participants were introduced to art, the range of media and invited to produce works for display and sale. A wine and cheese evening was held to celebrate the opening and many visitors were given a personal guided tour and opportunity to speak with the artists. Some of the artists were delighted when their works were sold.



Photo Left:
Men's Handyman Group

Photo Right:
African Men's BBQ





African Family Welfare Project

Joselyne Ntahomvukiye

Department of Families & Housing, Community Services & Indigenous Affairs

2010 has seen a big increase in the number of refugees and families in the Newcastle area from the Burundian, Rwandan and Congolese communities. From a starting point of 18 families (69 individuals) at the beginning of the period, an additional 12 families (45 individuals) were exited from their arrival support program to NSS hands. As well, there were three families relocated to Newcastle (12 persons) and 1 family (5 people) moved away. Most of the newer arrivals were Congolese, with others from Uganda, Somalia and Ethiopia.

All of the activities offered through parenting programs and life skills development are aimed at building self-reliance and empowering individuals, making settlement easier, reducing dependence and increasing opportunities for positive involvement in Newcastle society. This position is funded by NSS.

Casework and Referrals:

There were 1,483 requests for support from individuals during the year. These were mainly around housing, employment, language issues (translations and interpreting), parenting and education. Many of the clients who arrived in 2005/2006 are only now becoming confident to approach services on their own behalf (with a supporter) and to ask for an interpreter when necessary. Well over 1000 telephone requests were made in the same period for referrals and information.

Activities:

This community has been keen participants in all programs offered through NSS. Every woman in the group attended all of the Health and Pharmacy sessions during the year, and several have taken up sewing. Most of the women are involved in the African Training Markets and food handling training, while the men were very active in the Handyman training and BBQ skills.

The women have developed a dance and culture group to provide paid performances and cook traditional foods for sale. Money earned is put towards a communal bank account to pay for uniforms and supplies.

The Newcastle Burundian community hosted a visit by the Burundian community from Sydney in June, 2010, which was well attended.

Many of the women in the community obtained drivers' licenses in this period.

With encouragement from NSS, the community has become stronger and is looking for opportunities to build skills and businesses in the Newcastle area.



African Parenting Assistant
Amer Manyuon
 Department of Immigration & Citizenship

My role is to support the families and women who attend parenting programs at Penola House. As a member of the Sudanese community, I welcome others to sewing and cooking classes and provide language support to participants with the volunteers who are there to help us. Many of the clients who work with me have little English language and need a lot of help to take part in these classes. NSS pays me to work 7 hours per week.

Until the end of last year (2009) there were many people attending sewing classes and we learnt skills like how to use the machines, choosing patterns and projects such as making bags, clothing and patchwork quilts, choosing materials and cutting out, and finally how to finish off our work.

At the beginning of 2010, not so many people came to Penola because of TAFE classes and responsibilities, so we had to change the way we did things.

I became a general helper for anyone who dropped in from the African Communities, and showed the Burundian, Mauritanian, Equatorian, Dinka and Japanese women all that I know about sewing.



I can say there were more than 400 attendances at the sewing lessons in the year, although that includes some of the women attending twice a week for four months. I also made and received many phone calls from community members, for advice or asking me to make an appointment with members of my team or other NSS staff.

I became more confident in my language and was able to help with interpreting for Dinka women. I was very proud to be able to help my team with their clients.

I helped organise the African Community Consultation at NSS in June 2010. I rang everyone I could think of and invited them to come. Most of those I rang did attend. It was our first time to come together as African Communities and have the chance to give our stories and issues to an Australian service. It made me very proud.

The young women from my community formed a dance group and practiced every school holiday and weekends. They performed at a big Sudanese gathering in Sydney and at local community gatherings, led by Nina Meershak.

I am very happy being a member of the Refugee Support Team.

(as told to my team leader, Kiri Hata)



African Family Support Project (Mauritanian)
Alhousseynou Ly & Robyn Graham
 Funded by the Department of Immigration & Citizenship

This project provided much needed support to a highly disadvantaged group of refugee arrivals to the Newcastle region. Although there are only 7 families (44 individuals) it is one of only 2 communities of Mauritians in Australia. The aim of this support service is to provide information and referral, as well as facilitate access to mainstream services, for a group that has generally low levels of English language. The position is funded by NSS.

This community holds regular monthly meetings and has a leadership group who are developing their own networks and support systems.

Their commitment and success to maintain their culture and language is evidenced by the Community Language School they run each Saturday for all school-age children. None of the community spoke English when they arrived, but at least five have now reached proficiency and two are earning income as interpreters. Some of the community speaks French from their time as refugees in Senegal.

The need of this community is also clear in the numbers of requests we receive for assistance, now that the members are comfortable and confident in their relationship with NSS. Over 500 phone calls have been made or received to provide information and referrals. More than 400 meetings have been held with individuals and families to address issues and provide advice and support. Workers have also attended many of the community meetings.

ISSUES

Employment: At the beginning of the period, only 2 were employed as interpreters. By the end of the period, 9 men had found work and 3 women were completing applications for positions.

Housing: There are several large families in this group who required 5+ bedroom houses, many of which tend to be old and of low standard with many problems.

Health: All the interpreters are male and many of the sufferers are women. The Migrant Health Workers from NSW Health have been a great help and run health sessions for the women.

This community is fast approaching a level of integration within the wider community. Their independence grows each day and their main need is support with specific issues.

Note: Alhousseynou Ly (July – November 2009), Robyn Graham (December 2009 – April 2010)



Volunteer Co-ordination

Michael Freund (Educational Programs)

Georgina Ramsay (Welfare Programs)

Funded by Department of Immigration & Citizenship
- Settlement Grants Program (SGP)

The purpose of this position is to co-ordinate assistance for NSS refugee clients from people in the wider Newcastle community, through a range of volunteering programs.

The main job tasks are to: log requests for assistance from refugees, then recruit, register, police-check and match suitable volunteers to those requests. The specific activities of volunteers are then arranged with the refugee individual/family at a placement meeting, or at a program induction. Ongoing support is provided for all volunteer-client placements.

Changes to Position Structure

In July 2009 the position was expanded from 3.5 to 6.5 days per week, as DIAC commenced 2 years of funding for the NSS Homework Centres program. Michael was appointed manager of this SGP project, and also continued as Volunteers Co-ordinator, focussing on Educational programs for refugee students. Olivia Graham (right), then later Georgina, joined the team to co-ordinate the Welfare volunteering programs for refugee adults.



Volunteer Recruitment

Continual recruitment of new volunteers was again critical to the success of all volunteer programs. Recruitment was aided considerably by promoting our specific volunteering needs with the following services: University of Newcastle – Teach Outreach, iLEAD, and Careers Service; Hunter Volunteer Centre; NSS Volunteers website & mailing list.

Volunteer Registration

Each new volunteer was given an induction to NSS, including information about our organisation, services, locations, volunteering programs & policies, as well as background & cultural information on our refugee clients. New volunteers registered by filling out and signing these forms: 1) Volunteer Policy-Agreement; 2) Volunteer Information; 3) Prohibited Persons Employment Declaration; 4) National Criminal History Record Check. A photo was also taken of each new volunteer, for Administration to make the ID badge.

Table 1: Annual Volunteer Statistics

Volunteer Status	Vols.	% change from 2008-09
Enquiries received	245	-2%
Registered	147	-1%
Placed in Program	187	+15%
Re-started or Extended	57	+78%
Inactive (known)	125	+19%
Withdrew (known)	58	-24%

Table 1 (left) shows the volunteer statistics for the reporting year. As at 30 June 2010, a total of 190 registered volunteers were actively working in client programs, or awaiting placement. The main volunteering programs with numbers of participants are described below:

Homework Centre (HWC): 72 volunteers participated

The HWC program continued to expand, with a new centre at St. Pius and a significant increase in students at Hamilton, courtesy of funding by DIAC and Clubs NSW. Volunteers tutored a total of 80 students with homework, reading, etc, one afternoon per week, at:

- Hamilton Public School (Kinder-Yr.6, attending from several primary schools)
- St. Pius X High School, Adamstown (Yr.7-10)
- San Clemente High School, Mayfield (Yr.7-10)
- Waratah High School, Technology Campus (Yr.7-10)

Each centre was managed by a Co-ordinator employed by NSS. A parent information session was also held at each school, on topics such as student pathways after Yr.10.

In-Home Tutoring: 44 volunteers participated

Volunteers provided homework, reading, etc. support for students one-on-one in the client home, or local library, etc. Students ranged from primary school to TAFE/University level.

Volunteers in Schools Program (VISP): 14 volunteers participated

Volunteers provided in-class support for students, one-on-one at a range of local primary & secondary public schools. DET Refugee Support Officer, Renata Ninevski, ran VISP training sessions for the volunteers, and also facilitated their school placements.

Penola House: 55 volunteers participated

Volunteers at Penola House assisted men, women, and child clients in a broad range of activities, including: office/reception, child-minding, house searching, gardening, and various other special projects. A particular success was the establishment of the Penola House car driving program and volunteer assistance with ESL and Food Safety classes.



Driving Supervision: 21 volunteers participated

Volunteers supervised learner drivers to log the 120 hours necessary to apply for their 'P' licence. The establishment of the Penola House car driving program allowed a number of clients to participate in the driving program without having access to their own car.

Adult English Literacy: 18 volunteers participated

Volunteers provided English language support for adults, one-on-one in the family home, at NSS, at Penola House, etc. Citizenship preparation was also provided.

General Home / Family / Transport: 16 volunteers participated

Volunteers provided support within the homes of some client families, providing assistance in activities such as childcare and homecare. Volunteers also provided transport services for activities such as shopping, medical, welfare service appointments, etc.

Miscellaneous / Events: 11 volunteers participated

Volunteers assisted with one-off projects and activity days. A particular success was volunteer participation in the African Training Markets organised by Helen Buchanan.

Community Refugee Support Group

Our long-standing collaboration with the Community Refugee Support group came to an end, with co-ordinator Ron Davis disbanding CRS. The group was strongly active in local refugee welfare activities over many years. We wish Ron all the best for the future.

Acknowledgements:

A huge thank-you to all of our wonderful volunteers, without whom, none of these support programs are possible. NSS recognised the dedication of all active volunteers, by sending each person a gift and laminated certificate for Christmas. A special note of appreciation goes to our Homework Centres staff, **Renea Giles, Morgan Turner, Aidan Linehan & Georgina Ramsay**, whose commitment has made this growing project such a success. Thanks also to all Refugee Team workers, NSS office staff & management. We look forward to working with such great people next year, in supporting our refugee clients.

**Photos:**

Tutors & students at
NSS Homework Centre
(Hamilton PS)



WELFARE TEAM

Ms Petrona Kelly
Team Leader
Filipino Social Worker
Brighter Futures Coordinator

Ms Elena Ferguson
Russian Welfare Worker

Ms Nellie Srisurapon
Thai Welfare Worker

Ms Juanita Loli
Pacific Islander Welfare Worker
(Samoan)

Ms Finau Manu
Pacific Islander Welfare Worker
(Tongan)

Ms Miza Torlakovic
Multicultural Family Support Worker (Families First)



Filipino Welfare Project

Petrona Kelly

Funded by Department of Human Services,
Community Services Agency

This project provides support services to highly disadvantaged Filipino people, mainly women and children who are experiencing physical and psychological crisis and hardship through domestic violence, homelessness, mental health and isolation, immigration issues and other misfortunes encountered in their settlement.

Key Service Specifications of this project includes:

- ▶ Provision of information, options and referrals to client
- ▶ Provision of intervention/group work to individuals and families
- ▶ Provision of support and/or practical support/physical assistance to clients
- ▶ Advocate access to services for individuals and families
- ▶ Provision of community information or education to raise awareness, issues, services and activities
- ▶ Build and maintain community networks/service systems
- ▶ Plan, develop and support community building events.

The worker is available at NSS four days during the week.

This report covers the period 1st July 2009 to June 2010. This year, I have provided approximately 1,530 Face to Face (FF) & 1,242 (Phone/emails) instances of services to clients. Their issues are inter-related in many cases and on many occasions, a client presented a number of problems/needs.

As can be seen from the statistics (on the following table) client settlement information forms a significant part of my work; domestic violence, legal matters, immigration, housing & accommodation and income support & finances predominate as problem areas.

Issues/Problems Presented by Clients:

Issues/Problems	FF	Ph/Email	Issues/Problems	FF	Ph/Email
Immigration/Citizenship	120	90	Mental Health	45	45
Income Support & Finances	130	60	Childcare	40	20
Employment	40	30	Aged Care	40	25
Education & Training	61	45	Youth Issues	49	45
Overseas Qualifications	30	25	Legal Matters	132	75
Learning English	20	23	Police	20	14
Housing & Accommodation	123	70	Family Problem	90	70
Health	55	50	Settlement Information	260	200
Domestic Violence	135	105	Other	140	250
Total (Face to Face)	1530		Total (Phone/Email)		1242

Other Issues include: social/emotional problems, death & bereavement, separation & divorce, social isolation, gambling problem, neighbourhood disputes, unfair dismissal, harassment & discrimination, language difficulties, transport problems, filling of forms, passport renewals, court support, documents translations, supporting letters, traffic infringements, cultural information, income tax returns, referee, problem with real estate, JP signatures, etc.

Services Provided: Advocacy, counselling, referral & information, consultation (to & from), filling forms, letters of support, hospital/home visits, interpreting, general support, transport assistance, document translation, court support, JP signatures, etc.

Networking & Training:

During the year, I maintained networking with peers and colleagues and other service providers to further develop skills and enhance information level to better serve the needs of the Filipino community by attending the following trainings meetings, seminars, etc, NSS Caseworkers, Team Leaders, NSS Staff meetings, NSS Planning Day and NSS AGM, Occupational Health & Safety workshops, Filipino Carers Information sessions, Child Protection Breakfast, White Ribbon breakfast for the Elimination of Violence Against Women, CALD Foster Care Information session, Harmony Day, HPTACLS meetings, NOVA Management Committee meetings, Mental Health Legislative Training, Legal Aid Launch of New Resource Kit, Training on Engaging Men on Family Based Program, Opening of Samaritans' Toronto office, Workshop on Violence Against Women in Refugee Communities, Salary Sacrifice Information session, Keep Them Safe – Putting It Into Practice & Child Car Restraint Information Session.

Other Activities:

As the Team Leader of the NSS Welfare Team I have co-ordinated and organised monthly caseworkers meetings. I also have the task of completing NSS Service Specification & Achievement Performance reports of Community Services projects here at NSS such as the Russian, Thai, Tongan, Samoan and Filipino welfare. Being an accredited member & registered social worker with the Australian Association of Social Workers (AASW), I complete Statutory Declarations (DIAC Form 1040) for women who are in domestic violence situations and who are applying for permanent residency in Australia.

Likewise, I spent time co-ordinating the Filipino Choir of Newcastle in their rehearsals and performances. I am also very pleased to report that NSS Filipino Women's Group is stronger than ever. We meet every Friday.

Once again, it was another busy year. I would like to thank Violetta and Lulu and of all my colleagues for their continued support and encouragement, especially during my difficult time. Likewise, I would like to extend my thanks to the NSS Board for their unending support to the Filipino Welfare Project.



Brighter Futures Program

Petrona Kelly

Funded by Department of Human Services,
Community Services Agency
- Early Intervention Program

The Brighter Futures Program is an initiative of NSW Community Services funded to target early intervention support for vulnerable children and families. It involves case management, access to child care, parenting programs, home visiting and brokerage in order to improve emotional, social, health, educational and developmental outcomes for children and families.

Families enter the program in one of two ways: through DoCS Helpline, or through the community pathway which involves a referral from community source.

The target group for the Brighter Futures (BF) program is: families who are expecting a child or have child/children 8 years or younger, with priority given to families with children under 3 years of age and has stable accommodation in geographical catchment area.

Family Vulnerabilities:

Families must present with at least one of the following vulnerabilities that if not addressed could have a negative effect on parenting, family functioning and/or child well-being.

- Domestic violence
- Parental drug and alcohol misuse
- Parental mental health issues
- Lack of extended family or social support – social isolation
- Parents with significant learning difficulties or intellectual disability
- Child behaviour management problems, such as parent/child conflict, school problems, parenting difficulties.

To deliver such program in Newcastle and the Lake Macquarie areas is the Samaritans Foundation as the Lead Agency in collaboration with government & non-government agencies.

Northern Settlement Services (NSS) delivers the program to CALD families who are willing to participate in the program through home visitation.

The role of the BF home visitor is to build skills and capacity of the family including a positive relationship with the parents, referring clients to external services (in consultation with case manager), ensuring the wellbeing of children, providing parental support, advocating for clients e.g. for housing/Centrelink, writing letters of support, supporting court attendance, attending case meetings with case managers, teaching/mentoring living/housekeeping skills/life skills, providing general support, etc.

Working on the goals outlined in the case plans, this year, I had the task to home visit two families with five young children each, with complex issues and needs.

Other activities are the monthly meetings with other BF workers from various agencies, monthly reporting, some trainings and the annual conference.



There is great value & benefit for the clients & the agency through the work of this project. I would like to thank the Board & staff for their continued support of the program.



Russian Welfare Project

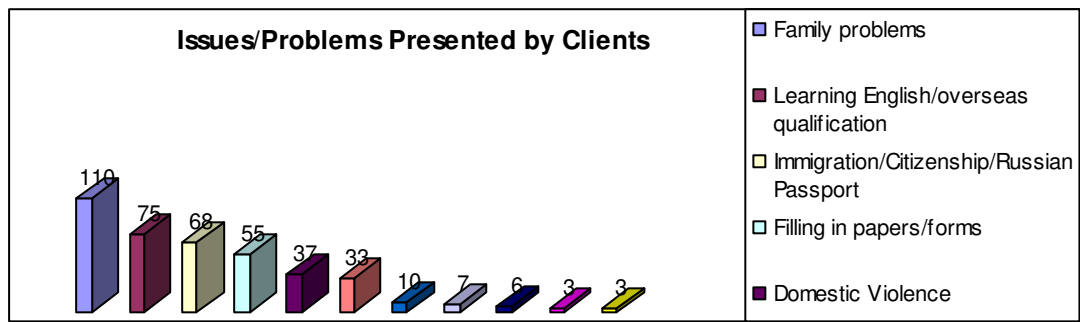
Elena Ferguson

Funded by Department of Human Services,
Community Services Agency

This project provides support services to disadvantaged Russian speaking people, mainly women and children who are experiencing immigration issues, social isolation, language problems, and difficulties in finding a job and therefore stress and frustration which creates barriers for their integration into this new country.

The Russian Welfare Worker is available at NSS for one day each week. This report covers the period from 01.07.09 to 30.06.10; during this time the Russian Welfare Project had 179 occasions face to face and 230 phone calls.

Presenting problems:



The table above indicates a predominance of clients seeking help with family problems, including social/emotional support and cultural information (110); this resulted from feelings of loneliness and isolation due to the distance from home and the clash of cultures within their own household and the outside community. Assistance with filling in papers and forms and help with translations were required during the year (55). Other areas where support was needed were education, learning English and overseas qualification issues (75); as well, Immigration/Citizenship/Russian Passport issues (68) where assistance was necessary; and issues with Domestic Violence 37 instances; plus, employment (33), income support/finances (10), driving tests (7), health (6), legal advice (3); and aged care (3) were problems presented during the year.

To provide community education and to raise awareness of health issues, information sessions were organised in partnership with Hunter New England Health: these were 'Migraine' and 'Eye Care'. A 'Drug and Mental Health' & Substance Use" were held in cooperation with Mental Health. Furthermore, an excursion to the Family Courthouse and a meeting with a lawyer were organised together with a 'Domestic Violence Education & Support' Project.

In addition, a Cooking Class and regular Russian language classes for children were held during the year (a minimum of 13 people attended each session).

The Russian language Newsletter "Berezka" was issued 6 times a year to 102 families, with information on Community meetings, gatherings, announcements, welfare services, together with cultural and linguistic materials. Also, brochures in the Russian language on issues such as: Law, Women's Health, and Centrelink & other services providing information for new arrivals.

The role of community development was supported through cultural events, celebrations and social gatherings (4) such as: the Celebration of International Women's Day (30 woman participated); a Family party with children's performances, cultural games, songs and dances (43 people attended); the Russian New Year party with Russian Santa Claus, children's stage performances, games and dancing (98 people); Russian Christmas party for children (15 families with 25 children attended).

One joint activity, the "Community Cultural Festival" was undertaken in partnership with The City of Newcastle, where NSS's Russian worker and the Russian group represented the Russian Community of Newcastle with a performance of Russian crafts, traditional costumes and other arts.

To build and maintain the community service systems networks, to promote best practice, improve the level of information exchange and service coordination the following meetings were attended during the year: Caseworkers meetings (6), NSS Planning Day NSS AGM, Centrelink Multicultural Forum, White Ribbon Day/Violence against Women, Child Support Day, OH&S trainings (2) Home visits, Mental Illness Hunter New England Health Unit/ Toward a Healthy Life, ABC/Newcastle Harmony Week interview, Central Coast Multicultural Expo

I have had a productive year studying for my Bachelor's Degree in Social Science and working with my compatriots in the Hamilton NSS office; and have enjoyed satisfaction in making the lives of my clients easier and more positive as they integrate into the Australian community.



Thai Welfare Project

Nellie Srisurapon

Funded by Department of Human Services,
Community Services Agency

This 2 day a week project provides support services to highly disadvantaged Thai people, mainly women and children who are experiencing hardship such as homelessness, mental health, isolation, physical & psychological crisis due to domestic violence, immigration issues, and other barriers detrimental to their settlement.

The Thai community in Newcastle, the Hunter and the Central Coast is steadily increasing. New arrivals are increasingly referred to NSS from within the community, as well as from other service providers.

There are now **210** Thai households on the mailing list, **an increase of 25%** from last year. On the Central Coast there has been nearly a **30% increase** with **82** households.

As you will see from the table below, domestic violence, legal matters and associated issues kept me with steady ongoing casework for most of the year.

SERVICE TYPE	FACE TO FACE	TELEPHONE
Immigration	22	174
Education & Training	6	96
Housing/Accommodation	16	86
Employment	4	25
Income support	17	71
Mental Health	7	94
Domestic Violence	51	240
Legal	45	339
Police	3	46
Family problems	6	91
Settlement	15	152
Health	11	137
Court Support	14	-
Home visit /out-assist.	88	-
Form filling	21	-
	TOTAL: 326	TOTAL: 1551

Other issues include: social/emotional, language difficulties, interpreting, cultural information, support letters, transport problems and social isolation.

A TOTAL OF 1877 INSTANCES OF SERVICE HAVE BEEN PROVIDED FOR THE THAI COMMUNITY AS WELL AS OTHER SERVICE PROVIDERS IN THE REPORTING PERIOD.

Referrals:

This year has seen an increase in referrals, especially from social workers from HNEAHS and Centrelink. Referrals have come from as far as Lismore and Port Macquarie. A good, dedicated lawyer has made the service much easier. Ben Huston, of Hunter Valley Legal, has provided his expertise and time to our clients on many occasions.

Women's Meetings:

To provide awareness in health & a chance for the Thai ladies to come together, network and to meet new people, eight information sessions were organized; six of these were in partnership with HNEAHS with around 8 to 25 people attending. Topics covered were Taking Medication, Women's Health, Using Interpreters, Drug and Alcohol, Sexual Health and Parenting Skills. Four meetings were held on the Central Coast & the other in Newcastle. The meetings were held on Saturdays and normally accompanied with plenty of food to eat.

Religious ceremonies:

The Thai community like to come together to pray and make merit on special occasions. Three religious events were held at Edgeworth Neighbourhood Centre with monks presiding and members from remote areas joining in the worship. These events are extremely popular and attendees can number up to 150.

Other activities:

During the year, I have attended 13 NSS Caseworker meetings, 4 DV meetings, 4 C.S. Caseworker meetings, Centrelink Forums, Car Seat Training, Triple P Training, Children Living with DV Workshop and NSS Planning Day.

PROJECT HIGHLIGHTS:

MEGA TRAINING DAY - Display table was set up at Central Coast to promote NSS programs and projects; networked with other services

MENTAL HEALTH EXPO – NSS Information display table.

CENTRAL COAST MULTICULTURAL EXPO – NSS display table; Distribution of NSS materials to other service providers. Thai community member demonstrated the art of fruit carving. Radio ABC interview before the event

HARMONY DAY – CENTRAL COAST- Organised Thai traditional dancing troupe, Fruit/vegetable/soap carving display, Thai food tasting & cooking demonstrations, NSS info table. 30 Thai members participated in the event

I would like to thank all colleagues for their ongoing support and especially my team leaders and the forever patient and accommodating Administration staff.

I would also like to wish Violetta all the best for the future, she will be sorely missed.
What a marvellous job you have done!!



Pacific Islander Welfare Project

Juanita Purcell-Loli (Samoan Welfare) & Finau Manu (Tongan Welfare)

Funded by Department of Human Services,
Community Services Agency

The Pacific Islanders Welfare Project Services (CS) aims to assist disadvantaged Pacific Islanders with issues relating to:

- Accommodation
- Domestic Violence
- Employment
- Health
- Immigration (Citizenship Application & Sponsorship)
- Legal
- Youth

The two workers aim to achieve objectives of:

1. Supporting children, young people, individual and families of Pacific Islanders to enable the enhancement of their independence, safety, self-esteem and or quality of life within the communities by:
 - i) providing information, advice, referrals and advocacy to individuals and families.
 - ii) providing group work to Pacific Island Women's Groups with 10 – 20 women.
 - iii) providing tax assistance through Tax Help Volunteer Programs (ATO)
 - iv) providing ongoing support, advocacy and casework services to client group through case plan.
2. Building strong communities and social capital / undertaking community development so that Pacific Island Communities are well informed, resourced, and connected and that equity and diversity are embraced by:
 - i) providing information via newsletters distributed monthly to the Samoans and bi-monthly to the Tongans. This includes details for family activities in the residing areas of the Pacific Islanders and information regarding changes to government policies etc. This enhances awareness of relevant services Pacific Islanders can access. Information is also transmitted on a weekly basis to the Samoan and Tongan Communities via the Community Radio programs on Radio 2NURFM 103.7 (Sunday nights for the Samoans & Friday nights for the Tongans) and is heard by an audience of 300 – 400.
 - ii) workers networking with government, non-government agencies and service providers via meetings for awareness and development. These include: Centrelink, Housing NSW, Community Services, Ethnic Communities Council, , Hunter Tenants' Advice /Advocacy Service, Legal Aid, Migrant Health Services, Police Department Charlestown, other NSS Meetings, Centrelink Multicultural Forum, CALD Advisory.

Other services provided is assessing NSS clients who need emergency relief or welfare assistance in paying bills ie Electricity, Gas and Water. Clients who visit the Office to obtain assistance with Tax Returns and Welfare Emergency Relief are not all of Pacific Island Background but are either Anglo Saxons with low income or Centrelink recipients as well as CALD.

They are either self-referred or referred by other service providers / or centre- based referrals. Ongoing case management provided with support given via home visits and referrals to other services.

ISSUES / PROBLEMS	Face to Face	Telephone Calls	Follow Up
Accommodation: Housing Issues	33	101	10
Employment: ie Resume Writing / Character References	9	19	1
Immigration Matters: Referrals / Sponsorships / Passport Applications / Renewals	30	35	7
Tax Help Program: Tax returns	166	30	5
Legal / Youth & Community	16	39	5
EAPA Income Support: (Welfare / Emergency Relief)	258	92	2
Justice of the Peace Assistance	37	11	0
Domestic Violence / Child Protection	1	5	1
Education / Training	3	7	-
Health	10	11	-

The Tongan welfare worker is available for 2 days a week.

It has been a productive and busy year for us though interesting particularly with Finau Manu, the new Tongan worker coming on board and working twice a week.

We appreciate the encouragement given by our Team Leader Pet Kelly, the assistance given by Mary Milevski and the Administration Team. We are also especially grateful to our CEO for her guidance and for always being supportive.



God bless you all and may you all have a happy and safe Christmas Break.



Multicultural Family Support Project (Families First)

Miza Torlakovic

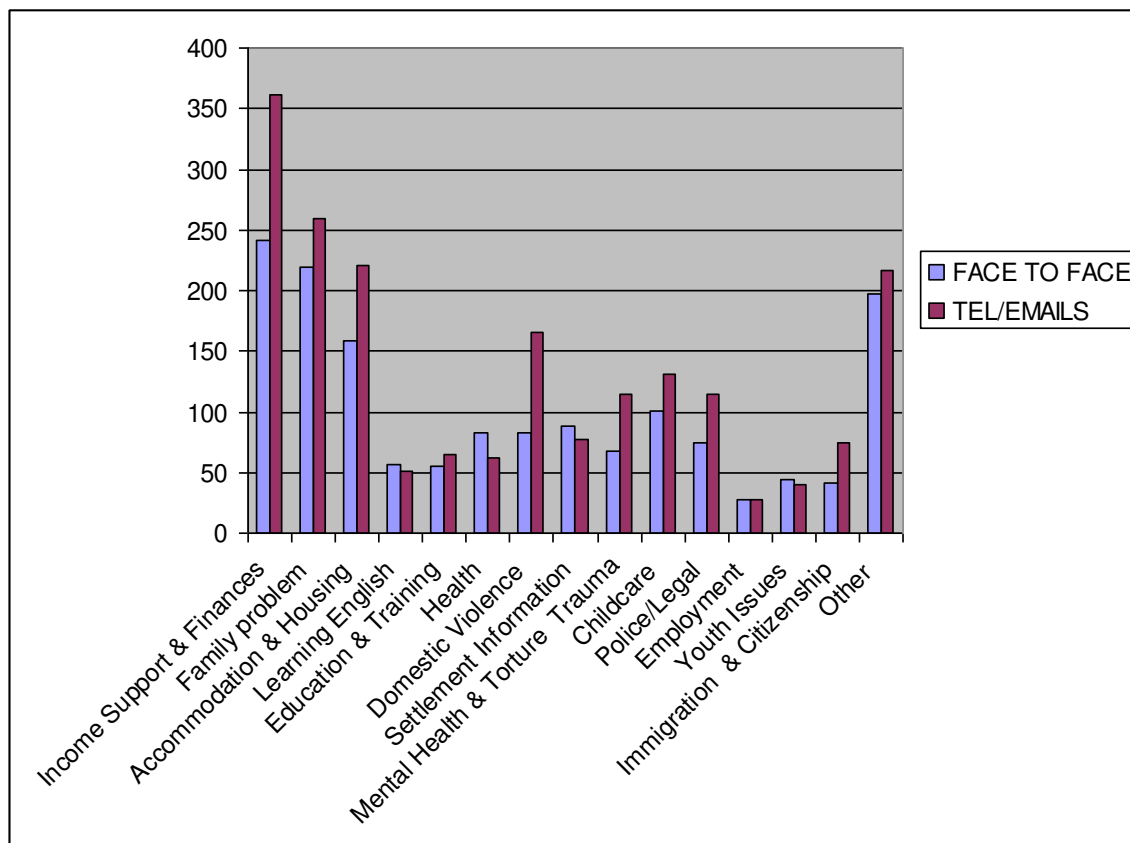
Funded by Department of Human Services,
Community Services Agency

The Department of Human Services, Community Services Agency funds the Multicultural Family Project under the NSW-Families First program. This project provides support to disadvantaged families comprising of new parents and families with children aged 0-8 from Culturally and Linguistically Diverse Backgrounds (CALD). The target group includes first time parents, teenage parents and parents with developmental disability; and/or other special needs, living in the Newcastle and Lake Macquarie LGAs.

Clients

This year, 69 families accessed the project, 41 which were new clients. The client group varies with no particular dominant migrant or refugee group. Referrals came from Hunter Area Health, Women's refuges, Child Care Services, Child and Family Health, Mental Health Services, Housing services, TAFE, Schools and Legal services. Likewise, through community services, other early intervention services as well as through NSS and self referrals.

Client Issues



Other* include material assistance, case conferences, isolation, home & hospital visits, filling of forms, documents, language problems, etc.

The table indicates the range of issues confronting families. As might be expected finance, accommodation, family relationships, and domestic violence required most attention.

Group Work

Throughout the year, several group activities were organised for CALD families to provide community education and information. These sessions were related to: Financial Support; (4) sessions; Accommodation and Housing; Language; Domestic Violence (3); Settlement Information; and Mental Health (6). Other group activities were presentation/promotions to Glendale TAFE students of NSS projects, Westlake FI Volunteers and ACON Services with a total of 159 individuals in attendance.

Community Capacity building

The project has been successful in working with other Government and Non-Government agencies, as well as other NSS projects. This included a six-week parenting group program, "Parenting in Different Cultures" for Japanese women delivered by Newcastle Family Support Services.

In partnership with Hunter Women's Centre, Warlga Ngurra Women's Refuge, Family Action Centre, ACON, and Domestic Violence Coordinator, NSS was involved in organising the International Women's Day Workshop for service providers working with women in the Hunter. The workshop was held at Hunter Women's Centre in March with the theme, "Partnership Pathways – Connecting Community". It was a very successful event with more than 80 service providers attending.

This year, a six-month pilot program targeting parents and carers from CALD communities was held with the topics, "Substance Abuse " and Mental Health Education". Participants were from the former Yugoslavia (Serbian, Bosnian, Macedonian, Croatian), Japanese, Thai, Russian, Pacific Islanders (Tongan, Samoan), Indonesian, Nepalese, Ghanaian, Iranian, Jordanian, Burundi, Kenyan and Spanish backgrounds. A total of 109 participants finished the program, the first of this type to run in NSW. A report was written and released by Multicultural Mental Health during Multicultural Mental Health Week last July.

Meetings / Committees

The project networked with services to promote activities and events. Activities and events participated include: Multicultural Health Week; "Re-partnering with children"; the Family Relationship Centre, Community Services, CALD Foster Parenting Information; Family and Parenting by Legal Aid NSW and White Ribbon Breakfast - International Day for the Elimination of Violence Against Women. Inter-agencies included: Lake Macquarie Interagency; Newcastle Interagency; Newcastle Migrant Interagency; the Hunter Refugee Support Network; Community Services' Hunter Central Coast Advisory Group, Hunter New England's Mental Health Multicultural Access Committee and Centrelink's Multicultural Forum, Early Childhood Intervention Coordination Program, Hunter Area Committee, Hunter Women's Domestic Violence Advocacy Service, Family In Sight and Multicultural Advisory Health Committee.

Training

Attended a practical one day workshop on Stepfamilies and was organised by Stepfamilies Australia and the topics included: Insight into stepfamilies including implications and issues for children, parenting versus step parenting, creative ideas when working with stepfamilies, disciplining and helpful and unhelpful communication.

Attended CALD Foster Parenting Session by DoCS and the launch of a new kit for Family Law and Parenting by Legal Aid NSW. This kit also covered what to do when previous orders are disobeyed and was launched by Federal Magistrate Lepthorn. This project coordinated and also attended "Violence Against Women in Refugee Communities" run by Education Centre against Violence, NSW. The course was held at NSS and was well attended by service providers.

The project continues to do well thanks to the unwavering support of the Board and Management. I would like to acknowledge the good work of my colleagues as well as the exceptional dedication of the CEO of the agency Violetta Walsh, who is in so many ways, an inspiration to the industry of migrant & refugee settlement services ...my very best wishes to you, always...

FINANCE & ADMINISTRATION TEAM Newcastle & Central Coast (CC)



Arlene Richards
Financial Controller



Marianne Mohr
Assistant Financial Controller



Wendy Kirkham
Finance Assistant
Administration Officer



Mary Milevski
Office Manager



Silvia Ruano-McLerie
Senior Administration Officer



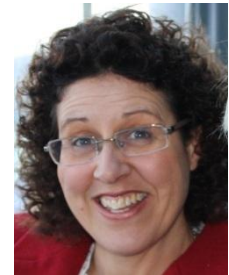
Helen Short
Administration Officer



Lydia Manusiu
Administration Officer



Jacinta Boidin
Administration Trainee



Helen Buchanan
OH&S Consultant



Trudy Wahl
Office Manager -CC
(Left Nov 2010)



Julie Styles
Administration Assistant-CC

CENTRE USAGE 2009 - 2010

African Community Council (Hunter)	United 'Boyce' Dance Troupe
African Girls Dancing	Migrant Health Unit
African Youth Group	Multicultural Dementia Carers Group
African Boys Dancing	Newcastle & Hunter Ethnic Choral Soc.
Ba'hai Community of Newcastle	Newcastle Multicultural Interagency
Burundi Community of Newcastle	Newcastle Akebono Japanese Group
Burundi & Congolese Community	Peruvian Group
Centrelink Multicultural Forum	Pacific RAC
Congolese Community	PCG Church
DIAC Immigration Officers	Russian Women's Group
Estonian Community of Newcastle	Russian School
Filipino Community Choir	Refugee Council
Filipino Women's Group	Refugee Week Organising Committee
Greek Macedonian Brotherhood	Samoan Women's Group
Pavlos Melas	
Hamilton Multicultural Walkers	Slovenian Association of Newcastle "Tivoli"
Hunter Refugee Network	Spanish Group
Hunter Community Legal Clinic	Tamil Language School
Migrant Interagency	Thai Dancing Group
International Singers	Tongan Choir
Latvian Group	United Nations Association Australia



[A Russian Community event held at the NSS meeting space during 2010]

Refugee Week Newcastle



NSS CEO Violetta Walsh with local member for Newcastle & Minister for the Hunter Jodi McKay, at the Markets



African Refugee Training Markets operated by
Northern Settlement Services
& supported by Penola House & Newcastle City Council

Includes some photos by Professional Photographer, Louise Whelan

Refugee Week Celebrations 2010



Includes some photos by Professional Photographer, Louise Whelan

Refugee Week Celebrations 2010



Councillor Peter Ducat ADC Mayor with Mr & Mrs Georkas, & Andreas Georkas all originating from Cyprus



The Mayor together with refugees Mr Simon Reech & Mary Dut



Tamworth Mayor James Treloar met Sudanese Refugees who have made Tamworth their home



Cr Larry Cameron with African refugees Rebecca Manyuon, Yar Maker & John Yol plant a tree in Campbell Park for Refugee Week

HMRS & CVS Outings

Carers, some clients & volunteers from both these groups attended a variety of outings this year...



In the studio audience at 'Ready Steady Cook' ,



Macadamia Farm—Medowie



Learning about the Macadamia's & having a taste!



Macadamia's—Fresh from the tree!



Cruising the shores of Lake Macquarie shores in the 'Supercat'